

extend to the market-dominated commercial culture. And whereas members of temperance societies and regular churchgoers tended to favor abstemiousness and greater self-control, partisans of the street scene were inclined to self-indulgence and boisterousness.

Leisure space, and even public space in general, was less a place of regular and coherent class assembly for members of New York's working families than such space was for the wealthy. There were important exceptions, of course. In May 1865, for example, the Workingmen's Union brought fifty thousand people to Jones Wood for an enormous picnic to launch a campaign for the eight-hour day. But the Fenian campaign to win freedom for Ireland by a plan to invade Canada gathered twice as many in the same spot the following year. The Fenian Rally—and innumerable smaller gatherings of Irish Catholic churches and German gymnastic societies—reflected the powerful ethnic accent in most working-class gatherings in these years. The associations that oversaw such leisure activities also incorporated an emerging middle class, often in leadership positions. If elite New Yorkers affirmed their common bonds through the fall carriage parade, working-class New Yorkers divided themselves into separate ethnic communities with their midsummer excursions.⁶⁹

Divided among themselves, working-class New Yorkers also stood outside the public created by the wealthy and the middle class in Central Park. In some cases, working-class New Yorkers distanced themselves in order to maintain ethnic, rather than American, traditions and ties. In other cases, they preferred pursuits that the native-born (and often nativist) Protestant middle class would have disapproved: gambling, heavy drinking, Sunday sports, and prizefighting, for example. Often expressive working-class styles of public behavior departed from bourgeois dictates of restraint and formality. Such preferences and differences help to explain why working families formed such a limited part of Central Park's cultural public in its first decade of operation, why that public achieved neither the unity nor the democracy promised by promoters.

The distinctions between the world of Jones Wood and the world of Central Park were, of course, not absolute, nor was New York's broad and diverse working class completely absent from Central Park. The park's design as a pastoral landscape excluded the attractions of the commercial pleasure garden, but working-class New Yorkers also enjoyed pursuing their amusements in a natural setting. Germans, who tended to spend their leisure time in family groups, were particularly likely to visit the park on Sundays, for example, and the park's appeal seems to have been greatest among workers who were "above the class that gravitates toward the engine house or the political club."⁷⁰ If most preferred Jones Wood, it was only partly because of differences in design or even accessibility. Equally important was who controlled Central Park. If time, money, and cultural preferences influenced whether working-class New Yorkers visited Central Park, the rules set by park officers determined whether they felt welcome to use this grand new public space.

9

"A PARK PROPERLY SO-CALLED"

In 1859 Frederick Law Olmsted reported to the Board of Commissioners of the Central Park an incident that he had found disturbing: "A private carriage containing a gentleman and ladies was observed driving through the narrow walks of the finished ground north of the pond, the wheels often running upon the borders and putting the trees and shrubbery recently planted in much peril." A "policeman hastened to remonstrate with the gentleman," but the offender retorted "angrily that the park belonged to the *public* and he should drive where he pleased in it."¹

Park policeman were more likely to clash with working-class park visitors than with gentlemen like this one, but the incident illustrates issues that resonated through the history of Central Park. What is proper behavior in a public park? Who decides? Who is the "public" of this public park? New Yorkers would wrestle for generations to come with questions they confronted for the first time in the late 1850s and the 1860s. Never before had they had such a vast public space, and its organization and management raised novel and difficult questions about the meaning of the "public."

Central Park and Jones Wood were both public parks in the sense that they were open to anyone in the city who chose to visit them, though Jones Wood was privately owned and operated for profit, and Central Park was owned by the city and managed, at least in theory, for the benefit of all New Yorkers. Still, public property was not to be mistaken for common property. As representatives of the "public," government officials—the Central Park commissioners—set rules for permissible use of the park. During its first decade, Andrew Green, Olmsted, and the force of park keepers governed this public space. Some park users ignored or disobeyed various of the rules and regulations, but in the 1860s at least, enforcement brought behavior into conformity with the prescriptions of

gentlemen who hoped to instruct the public in manners and values. Central Park was open to the public, but not all behavior was equally welcome there.

Training the "Ignorant" How to Use a Park

Olmsted claimed credit for crafting the park's rules and enforcement procedures; in 1863 he informed Calvert Vaux that the "administration & management of the public introduction to and use of the park" was his "most valuable property" in the entire project. But Olmsted hardly shaped the rules for park use by himself. The board of commissioners had begun to consider park ordinances and policing before Olmsted joined the staff as superintendent. They did ask him to draft the regulations, and the first set of rules seems to have been devised by Olmsted in collaboration with his rival, Chief Engineer Egbert Viele. Olmsted himself held undisputed authority over the park for only a brief time between his appointment as architect-in-chief in May 1858 and Andrew Green's appointment as comptroller in October 1859. He and Vaux resigned as landscape architects in 1863 and they returned in that capacity two years later. Their connection to the park was interrupted again when Tammany Democrats captured the board from 1870 to 1871 but resumed in November 1871. A year later Olmsted and Vaux dissolved their partnership; Olmsted continued on the park in various superintending positions until 1877, and Vaux was a consulting landscape architect for some of this time. Park politics, however, constrained Olmsted's control of the park keepers and other administrative matters.²

Olmsted had set the tone for public use of Central Park in the first place back in the 1850s. "A large part of the people of New York," he told the commissioners shortly after he was hired as superintendent, "are ignorant of a park, properly so-called. They will need to be trained to the proper use of it, to be restrained in the abuse of it, and this can be best done gradually, even while the Park is yet in process of construction." From the start, he was determined to "train" the public to understand the difference between this park and other open spaces; he drew a particularly sharp line between public property (as government-owned property) and both unregulated private property and common property. "Visitors to the Park, should be led to feel as soon as possible," he declared, "that wide distinction exists between it and the general suburban country, in which it is the prevalent impression of a certain class that all trees, shrubs, fruit and flowers, are common property."³

Olmsted hit on the same theme fifteen months later just as the first ice skaters were venturing onto the frozen lake. The *New York Times* reprinted and expanded on his remarks on the importance of "instructing [people] in the proper use of the park." The "careless stupidity" Olmsted discovered among early park users came from the mistaken notion that a park was like a "wood," with which Americans associated "the idea of perfect liberty." The *Times* agreed



The Park Proper: A promenade along the Lake.

with the need to distinguish parks from what it called "common spaces." Central Park should not be treated like other public spaces in New York City, which it believed the municipal government had surrendered to "sharps and rowdies": "The treasury, the streets, the wharves, the City Hall, the urinal, the Court-rooms, 'the [City Hall] Park' have all been left to the care of the elements and the speculators; so that the mere fact of a piece of ground's belonging to the public has become very naturally to be considered by the less intelligent classes . . . a license to commit nuisance on it. . . . Everyone must cease as soon as possible to associate [Central Park] in his mind with the dirty play-ground in front of the City Hall or Jones' Wood."⁴

Writing on the aesthetic motive of the Greensward plan in 1859, Olmsted had explained that the park "should present an aspect of spaciousness and tranquility . . . thereby affording the most agreeable contrast to the confinement, bustle, and monotonous street-division of the city. The Park should . . . as far as practicable, resemble a charming bit of rural landscape, such as, unless produced by art, is never found within the limits of a large town."⁵ For Vaux this aesthetic goal had the intrinsic value of creating a beautiful public space that

could be enjoyed by all citizens, but for Olmsted it incorporated the larger social motive of improving public behavior and assuaging competitive individualism.

In defining the park as an antidote to the strains the city imposed on the "nerves and minds" of its residents, Olmsted (who regularly worked himself into nervous exhaustion) probably had people like himself in mind. Yet he disavowed any class bias in spelling out his social motives. "The primary purpose of the Park," he wrote, "is to provide the best practicable means of healthful recreation for the inhabitants of the city, of all classes," including "the poor and the rich, the young and the old, the vicious and the virtuous." Moreover, when he talked about the need to train the public, he drew his examples of improper park use from the upper and lower classes alike.⁶ He was convinced that the only way to protect Central Park as a unified work of landscape art was to keep people from damaging the turf, the plantings, and the drives.

Although Olmsted did not direct his prescriptions for proper park behavior and use at any particular class, his ideas were nonetheless shaped by his own class and culture and by his personal experiences. Rejecting the views of his "cowardly conservative" opponents, for whom class-based cultural divisions were fixed, he believed members of the lower classes should and could acquire "the refinement and taste and the mental & moral capital of gentlemen." The "moral influence" of public parks, like that of public schools and libraries, offered a way for the working classes to acquire that "capital" as a means of cultural improvement. Although Olmsted did not accept the concept of immutable class distinctions, he disliked mobility motivated by materialistic ambition. Common cultural pursuits should reinforce the "simple and sensible social life."⁷

Olmsted's definition of democracy had no room for the sort of grass-roots participation advocated by artisans in the cooperative movement in the 1850s or the Knights of Labor and the populists slightly later in the century. Democracy, he believed, required the leadership of an appointed board of "gentlemen," and he enthusiastically supported the use of such a board to keep the park out of the hands of local Democratic politicians. "Refinement and taste" and "proper" park decorum implicitly excluded the sort of lively amusements and recreations that German and Irish immigrant workers pursued a few blocks east at Jones Wood and on the city streets.

The Sparrow Cops

In 1858 the state-appointed police commission granted policing authority to officers nominated and paid by the park board. Olmsted organized his twenty-four park keepers along paramilitary lines; he insisted on military salutes and



Gatekeepers posted at the entrances helped the park police enforce rules such as the one forbidding the use of drives by commercial vehicles.

clothed his corps in uniforms that the Democratic *Leader* ridiculed as aristocratic imitations of the garb of Windsor Forest's keepers. (Later, the gray-coated park keepers would be nicknamed "sparrow cops," in disparaging reference to the less dangerous beat they walked than those of the blue-coated city police.) By the spring of 1859 he had spelled out an elaborate set of "Rules and Conditions of Service." Each park keeper was required to "carry himself erect" and to "march at a quick step from one part of his beat to another." He was forbidden to "converse with visitors unless first addressed by them"; to use "harsh, exasperating or unnecessary disrespectful language"; to drink "ardent spirits" on the job or to frequent "taverns or tippling houses" off the job. Keepers were to appear "perfectly clean, hair brushed, beard combed . . . and in full uniform in every particular, cloth clean, brass polished, shoes clean and newly oiled or polished, coat buttoned to the neck and no white collar visible, gloves clean." Soon Olmsted was insisting that the keepers be ready for quizzes on their "ability to direct strangers to different parts of the park."⁸

Following Olmsted's lead, the sparrow cops rigidly policed their domain.



This *Vanity Fair* cartoon from 1863 suggests that the park police spent considerable time trying to control the antics of young parkgoers.

Almost immediately after the skating lake opened, one young man who stole a pair of skates was promptly arrested, and the police sought a stiff sentence that would make an example of him. He got thirty days in jail. In the same year, the keepers even picked up a supreme court judge for walking across some freshly planted grass. Though the judge was not prosecuted, strict enforcement of park regulations across class lines shocked some well-to-do New Yorkers. "Persons who have cut or broken shrubs," Olmsted complained, "will hardly ever believe that an officer has not exceeded his duty in arresting them until brought before the magistrate. I have been frequently sent for, in the confident supposition that I would reprove an officer for arresting a man for merely cutting a common branch, or pulling up a root of sassafras."⁹ Needless to say, he did not.

But despite their military bearing and their vigilant enforcement of the rules, Olmsted saw the keepers more as teachers than policemen. "The chief duty of the Park Keepers," he wrote, "is by timely instruction, caution and warning to prevent disorderly & unseemly practices upon the Park, and thus as far as practicable to avoid occasions for arrests." Considering the 2 million or so visitors who came to the park in 1859, the 228 arrests that year seem quite modest, and on a per-visitor basis, the 1859 haul was roughly eight times higher than the park arrest rate for the rest of the 1860s.¹⁰ Perhaps Olmsted shifted his keepers away from a rigorous arrest policy because it annoyed elite patrons. Or

perhaps the hard line taken in the first year succeeded in "training" visitors in proper park use, and violations diminished. Most likely, both were true.

"Fast Trotting," "Vulgar" Wagons, Gambling, Hawking, and "Indecent Language"

About half the rules focused on proper movement through the park, reflecting the emphasis of the Greensward plan on the visitors' relationship to the scenery. Parkgoers were enjoined to enter only at the specified gateways, to use the paths (not the grass), and not to block the roads with horses or carriages. More than a hundred signs scattered across the park directed the movement of individuals through the landscape and to particular features.¹¹

Two other rules on movement affected who would use the park and how. The first concerned speed limits. In an effort to keep out sporting men and trotting matches, the Greensward plan had omitted long, straight drives; nonetheless, some newspapers worried that Central Park might turn into an "aldermanic commons for fast driving." It was a realistic fear. In the 1850s harness racing was the nation's leading spectator sport, according to sports historian Melvin Adelman, and New York City had at least seven trotting tracks. The *Irish News*, reflecting the cross-class nature of the sporting crowd, bemoaned the absence of "a raised, broad carriage and equestrian drive, round the park," a "grand Excelsior Course" that the "great Equestrian Order of New York" could "race and rattle over, to their hearts' content." "Is there any amusement in the world," it asked rhetorically, "which we prefer to . . . the whirling action of a gay nag throwing one mile behind her in three minutes?"¹²

Trotting matches and fast driving did not "stir the blood" of most park commissioners as it did the editors of the *Irish News*. The preliminary rules recommended to the board in September 1859 set the speed limit for carriages at five miles per hour and for horses at six. When the preliminary regulations were reported, one board member, the well-known fancier of fast horses August Belmont, moved to raise the speed limit for carriages to eight miles per hour and to eliminate all speed limits on the bridle paths. The board settled on a compromise of seven miles per hour for carriages and ten for saddle horses.¹³

Belmont had specifically crafted his proposal to "keep the fast-trotting men and other rowdies out" of the park. As his biographer explained, Belmont "liked to race horses on and off the racetracks," but "he did not think the park would be an appropriate setting for anything that might be dangerous to wives and children." Moreover, he was shifting his affections from harness racing to thoroughbred racing, then emerging as the favorite sport of wealthy New Yorkers. He regarded the heterogeneous sporting crowds that gathered to join in (and bet on) street harness races as an inappropriate constituency for Central Park.¹⁴

Despite speed limits and curved roads, the park initially proved "vastly attractive to the trotters," but soon regular arrests "made generally understood," as the *Atlantic Monthly* reported, "the law and customs of the park . . . restricting speed to a moderate rate." Between 1862 and 1863, speeding arrests dropped by two-thirds. The ban on fast driving was intended to ensure not only safety but also gentlemanly refinement. The *Herald* explained that "the rowdy habit of rapid driving" excluded a man from "the recognized list of gentlemen. . . . Any person thus demeaning himself upon a public fashionable promenade would be as indelibly stamped as ill-bred as if he were to be found running violently up and down a ball room in the midst of the dance."¹⁵ Just as women governed manners within the ballroom, they would also determine what constituted decorum on the park drives.

If the park was like a ball room, not only certain speeds could be judged "vulgar" (as the *Herald* put it) but certain types of vehicles as well. The thousands of commercial wagons owned by cartmen, undertakers, and other tradespeople that filled the city streets were, from the start, barred from the park. Regulations prohibited omnibuses and express wagons, as well as "any cart, dray, wagon, truck, or other vehicle carrying goods, merchandise, manure, soil, or other article." Olmsted's ban was intended to provide a noncommercial alternative to the city streets, but it had class implications. His "business regulation," explained one local newspaper, would prevent the "invasion of the Central Park by improper vehicles and improperly behaved persons" and would thus keep the park from being "deserted by the better classes of our population."¹⁶ At a stroke, Olmsted and the commission stopped butchers and bakers from joining bankers and brokers on the drives.

Trouble broke out almost immediately. Just a few months after the carriage drives opened, Olmsted reported that "frequent altercations take place between gatekeepers and persons endeavoring to enter the park with vehicles which gatekeepers judge should be excluded in obedience to the ordinances." "Some of our wagon-owning citizens," the *Times* noted around the same time, "have been already greatly aggrieved at finding themselves excluded from the 'people's park' by the 'people's policemen,' when they took their families there for a Sunday's drive in the respectable vehicles which do duty during the week in transporting legs of mutton, or cans of milk, or kegs of crackers, or boxes of candles from their shops to the customers' houses." These "sufferers . . . instantly break forth into indignant denunciations of the 'aristocracy,' and impassioned vindications of the 'rights of labor.'"¹⁷

Perceiving the implicit class bias in the park regulations, the *Leader* sarcastically praised them for setting out "what is *au fait* in a place of public resort" and wondered whether "our democratic citizens" would be "turned out of the enclosure as Adam and Eve were kicked out of the Garden of Eden." In prohibiting gambling, gaming, fortune-telling, hawking, peddling, or any other unlicensed commercial activity, the board had excluded not only the activities

many wealthy New Yorkers found disagreeable but the equally disagreeable people who enjoyed them. Not coincidentally, the regulation against "threatening, abusive, or indecent language" followed the rules against peddling and riding in commercial wagons and preceded the rule on gambling and fortune-telling. In the mid-nineteenth century, respectable New Yorkers lumped these activities together as part of a lower-class street scene. Such prohibitions furthered Olmsted's larger aspiration to set the park apart from other urban public spaces, to institute "the most agreeable contrast" to the "bustle" of the city.¹⁸

Other rules adopted in 1859 insisted on the distinction between the park and the woods or the commons. One regulation explicitly barred visitors from cutting, breaking, or defacing the trees, shrubs, and plants, and another prohibited "persons" from turning cattle, horses, goats, or swine into the park to graze. In effect, officials wanted to ensure that the park would not be "common," in either sense of the word—nonexclusive or low and vulgar.

Olmsted's early efforts to grapple with the problem of controlling public use of Central Park could not entirely anticipate the controversies that would emerge when it opened. Within a year of adopting the original park ordinances, for example, the board added rules forbidding swimming or fishing in the ponds, setting off fireworks, playing musical instruments, displaying any "flag, banner, target or transparency," posting any bills or notices, or parading in military or target company or civic processions.¹⁹

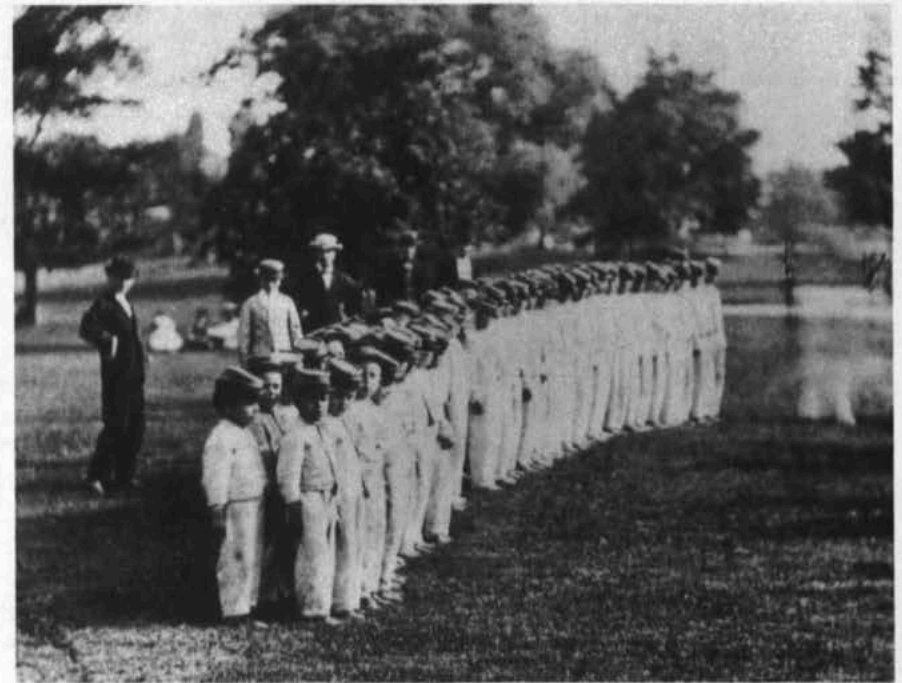
From Olmsted's perspective, however, the most persistent threat to the park came from any destruction of the turf. The original ordinances did not include the later infamous "keep off the grass" rule, but the first visitors did find placards advising: "For the Present Visitors are Prohibited to Tread on the Grass." The seemingly temporary ban (justified by the newly seeded lawns) became permanent. By fall 1860 the first item on the poster that listed park regulations warned visitors "not to walk upon the grass; (except of the Commons)." Olmsted had decided to ban walking on the meadows but to permit exceptions by labeling some areas either temporarily or permanently as "commons," thus ceding some public right of free access. Park officials allowed Saturday visitors to use the lawns, particularly the twenty-two-acre Green in the center of the park (originally called the Parade and later known as the Sheep Meadow). But as the *News* pointed out in 1860, such park regulations did not permit "the family of the poor artisan," who could only visit on Sunday, to "carry the basket of cheap luxuries, a few apples or peaches, the home made pie and sandwiches . . . and sit and enjoy them under one of the trees of the only rural retreat open to him and his after the confining toils of the week." Olmsted's effort to preserve the lawns interfered as a practical matter with one of his own announced goals for the park: to provide the opportunity for poor families to enjoy as well as contemplate nature.²⁰

Adelman notes, of "the growing rowdyism . . . and especially gambling and partisanship" that was infecting baseball. "Indeed," comments another sports historian, "the revenues from liquor sales and gambling were the engines driving the sports boom of the 1850s."²⁵

New Yorkers organized new baseball clubs almost weekly in the late 1850s at the same time that the city swallowed up many of the available playing fields—the "out-lying common[s]," as a sporting paper called them. The ball clubs saw the new park as the answer to their dreams, but Olmsted and the board began to wonder whether their presence might prove, instead, to be a nightmare. In May 1861 the commission rejected the applications of baseball clubs for use of the park. "It is obviously impossible," it explained, to accommodate more than fifty ball clubs with more than fifty members each; "the space is not sufficient." Nor, the board explained in a later annual report, would it be possible "to satisfy the requirements of the numerous cricket, ball, and other adult clubs within the area of the Park, and at the same time preserve in the grounds an appearance that would be satisfactory to the much more numerous class that frequent the Park for the enjoyment of the refined and attractive features of its natural beauties." "The Park," the 1861 annual report had similarly noted, "has attractions to those that visit it, merely as a picture. . . . Whatever defaces or injures this picture makes it less attractive to the great mass of visitors, and should, for the general good, be excluded." Moreover, as the board later said, banning the ball clubs "effectually prevented" "match games and the objectionable features that have been the frequent attendant of these games."²⁶

If the park board would not allow baseball and cricket clubs, what was to be done with the playgrounds that had been in the plans from the start? After nine years of intensive discussion, probably under the influence of Andrew Green, a former president of the board of education and now comptroller of the park board, the commissioners restricted the playgrounds to schoolboys who could produce a certificate of good attendance and character from a teacher. And even these exemplary lads found the fields open to them only three days of the week. Working-class youths were largely excluded, since relatively few of them went beyond elementary school in this period.²⁷

A year after the commissioners opened the fields to schoolboys, they made a similar arrangement for girls. In 1867 they permitted schoolgirls to play croquet (whose popularity had boomed in the United States after the Civil War) on the lawns three afternoons each week. (Adults were permitted to play on the East Green.) Several contestants in the design competition, aware of the growing interest in physical fitness for women at midcentury, had proposed equipped fields for women's gymnastics, but these suggestions were not pursued by the commissioners, because they feared that equipped fields would detract from the park's scenic beauty.²⁸ The genteel and restrained game of croquet, whose movable equipment could be stored, fitted better with the designers' conceptions of a natural park. The park would be open to women's recreation, but only



Only schoolboys with a note from their principal were permitted to use the ballfields in the 1860s. But youthful players varied in their decorum—as these contrasting images suggest.

to those genteel and restrained forms of exercise that the park's male managers deemed appropriate. Of course, many "respectable" women probably shared the board's view that men's sports and games impinged on their own enjoyment of the lawns and the drives.

"The most generally attractive features of the Park," the 1863 annual report argued, "are its natural beauties" and "a much larger number of persons derive gratification from the appearance of the lawn well preserved, than . . . [from] the practice of any special amusement that would destroy it." More than the greatest good for the greatest number was at stake. The commissioners and Olmsted as park superintendent were making a *choice* about what they considered to be a "proper park"—a choice with some significant implications for park use. Certain modes of park use were more proper than others. The report conceded, for example, that the "Sicilian and Scotchman are dissimilar" in their habits and traditions and that "individuals, even of the same nationality" have diverse habits and interests. "There is, however, a universality in nature," it maintained, "that affords a field of enjoyment to all observers of her works."²⁹

Despite the board's universal claims, such policies favored individual recreation and exercise over group play and games, particularly those of chance, competition, make-believe, and simulation. The park did not prohibit active uses by small informal groups—walking, horseback riding, carriage driving, and skating were all encouraged—but Olmsted and Green regarded those activities as purposeful (they provided exercise) and directed (they moved parkgoers through the landscape). But they avoided undue stimulation or excitement. Emerging park policy also favored visual over multisensual experiences, mental relaxation over physical exertion. One 1860s park report, for example, acknowledged the "pleasure found in walking on a lawn" but said that such pleasure would interfere with the lawn's more important "power to gratify by sight." Another report explained that the park should provide "a succession of views of a rural character," since these are "the natural food and refreshment of the human eye."³⁰

Parades, Picnics, and "Places of Entertainment"

The preference for the individual over the group extended well beyond sports. Guidebooks from the 1860s frame the park experience largely as a series of individual encounters with nature.³¹ This focus meshed well with Olmsted's notion of the park's contribution to individual moral improvement and "sensible" sociability, though not with the experience of wealthy carriage riders, who were likely to be judging one another's financial rather than moral "capital" and disregarding the scenery.

Even before the park opened the board had moved to block or restrict that group activity (and spectacle) most widely assumed to be part of a public park—

the drills and displays of target and military companies. In 1858 they had reduced the Greensward plan's original provision for a twenty-five-acre Parade. Then, the Parade literally disappeared; when Olmsted reported to the commission on the work done as of January 1859, he referred to the area as "a country green or open common." Soon, official documents and unofficial guidebooks began labeling that site (now only twenty-two acres) the "Green." The expectation of military processions and drills in the park persisted, nonetheless, and Olmsted acknowledged in his 1859 report that the Green "may be used upon special occasions for military displays." Yet when military companies turned up at the board offices in 1859 and 1860, they were briskly told that such activities were "incompatible" with the park's "objects." The sense of incompatibility was no doubt reinforced by the growing association of militia and target companies with the rowdy working-class culture of the saloon, the fire company, and the political clubhouse.³²

When the park's own keepers formed the Renwick Guard with the intention of setting off on a target excursion outside the park, Olmsted refused to let them wear their park uniforms or to parade "in such a manner as would cause them to be recognized as keepers of the park." Nor would he permit them to use his name as a sponsor. Green was equally negative, concluding that a target excursion "will not elevate the force in the public estimation, and is objectionable on their own account as well as on account of the Park." The "manners of a crowd attending any great muster of militia [are] always . . . particularly antagonistic" to what he had sought in Central Park, Olmsted later observed. Military parades in the park, he declared, would make it "subject to the humor of a multitude as uncontrollable and as dangerous to all that is peculiarly valuable in [Central Park] as a street mob is found to be when it has broken into a private house."³³

The coming of the Civil War accelerated the pressure to permit military drills in Central Park, but the board continued to resist, defiantly asserting the pastoral quality of the Green by grazing sheep on it. (It was because of the sheep, introduced around 1864, that some began calling it the Sheep Meadow, a name that took hold in the early twentieth century.) But neither board resolutions nor the grazing sheep stopped the First Division of the New York State National Guard, which simply marched onto the Green in April 1864 and began to drill and parade. Another regiment followed. The park keepers stood by helplessly as the troops marched through the gates. Responding to this blatant defiance of park rules—no doubt understandable in the midst of a war—Green in 1865 secured passage of a state law explicitly banning military parades in Central Park. But the issue of whether the park should accommodate parades or other large gatherings persisted.³⁴

So did the problem of large picnics. Sometime during the park's first year, officials apparently decided to ban all group picnics. Recalling a recent Methodist Sunday school picnic in the park, the *Times* commented in August 1860



This 1862 lithograph shows the sort of scruffy and disorderly militia company that Green and Olmsted wanted to keep out of Central Park.

that "such scenes are no longer permitted." It conceded that "the mere fact of an orderly and well behaved set of Sunday School scholars going to the park for a day's recreation and taking their lunch with them would, in itself, do no harm or bring disgrace upon the management." Nevertheless, to allow Sunday school picnics would open the door to excursions of "military or fire engine companies," which in turn would "require all the force under [Police] Superintendent Kennedy to keep order and preserve the peace."³⁵ German singing societies and Irish Catholic churches could not organize an excursion to Central Park like those they enjoyed in Jones Wood.

Some of the most troublesome demands to use the park came from those with something to sell. "Having become the resort of large assemblages of people," the commissioners explained in 1863, "the Park is considered too advantageous a field for advertising to be neglected by those who would force their wants or wares upon the public attention at every turn." Such commercial interest, they believed, posed a threat to the park's integrity: "If all the applications for the erection and maintenance of towers, houses, drinking fountains, telescopes, mineral water fountains, cottages, Aeolian harps, gymnasiums, observatories, weighing-scales, for the sale of eatables, velocipedes, perambulators, Indian work, tobacco, segars, for the privilege of using steam-engines, snow-shoes, ice-boats . . . were granted, they would occupy a large portion of the surface of the Park . . . and give to it the appearance of the grounds of a country fair, or of a militia training-field."³⁶

The *Irish News*, however, saw Central Park more as "a hippodrome than a pedestrian pleasure ground," and it urged the opening of "a number of refresh-

ment houses for—anything you please." The commissioners were not prepared to allow "anything you please," but they did realize that a proper bourgeois park should incorporate facilities to accommodate the expectations of respectable parkgoers, who were dining out with increasing frequency in this era. Olmsted himself pointed out that the failure of the park to offer satisfactory eating facilities left patrons to make their own arrangements. Some parkgoers "came supplied with baskets of food and drink" and left the park cluttered with "litter and debris"; others resorted to the fifty "shanty dram shops" and the more than half a dozen "larger establishments" for the sale of liquor that had sprung up near the park by spring 1860. One such place even made "a speciality of selling liquor in pocket flasks, with lunches, to be carried into the park," Olmsted told the board.³⁷

The way to defuse the "danger of disorder" posed by these "low dram-shops" was for the park itself to provide food and drink in a regulated setting. By licensing refreshment places, the board could keep people away from the surrounding saloons, control what was sold in the park, and also benefit financially from license fees. Over the next several years, therefore, the commission implemented a policy of controlled commercialism, allowing the sale of refreshments, the rental of ice skates and boats, and a carriage service. In doing so, they tried to ensure that business activities would conform to their notions of order and propriety. Regulations of boat rental, for example, specified the prices, the number of passengers allowed, and even the colors of the boats; the boatmen were required to have "sober habits," to refrain from smoking, to wear a "suitable uniform," and to "be respectful and obliging in their deportment." At the same time, the board rejected dozens of applications for permission to operate other activities, ranging from weighing scales to concert halls. So frequent were the requests that Olmsted developed a form letter telling amusement entrepreneurs that "the Commission does not at present seem to contemplate the establishment of any places of entertainment upon the park the ensuing season."³⁸

The Fight over Sunday in the Park

In the 1860s countervailing pressures for park use came to a head in a sharp controversy over Sundays in the park. That confrontation emerged in the context of a larger struggle over how New Yorkers should spend the Christian sabbath. Members of Presbyterian, Dutch Reformed, and Methodist churches urged a quiet, church-centered Sunday. More liberal denominations and "free thinkers" tolerated a wider range of activities, and tens of thousands of European immigrants, particularly Germans, favored even more secular and permissive sabbath pursuits. In April 1857 "leading Christian citizens" organized themselves into the New York Sabbath Committee to fight for the maintenance

of existing Sunday blue laws prohibiting commercial activities. Most of its elite leaders—lawyers, merchants, importers, company presidents—were active in the city's missionary and Bible societies.³⁹

This sabbatarian revival occurred at the same time as a well-organized antisabbatarian movement gathered force in the city's growing German community. "In the mid-1850s," Stanley Nadel observes in his history of Little Germany, "the most important issue for the masses was neither slavery nor wage slavery but rather the defense of their right to recreation." In September 1859 the antisabbatarian American Society for the Protection of Civil and Religious Liberty applied for permission to hold Sunday music concerts in Central Park; the *Staats-Zeitung* backed the plan, arguing that Sunday concerts would make music in the park available to those workers and shopkeepers who worked on Saturdays. The park board dodged the issue by tabling the motion.⁴⁰

But the matter was not settled. The following summer, when the board considered proposals for boat service in the park, Commissioner Waldo Hutchins, a nativist and a Presbyterian, moved that any license for such services specify that no boats be operated on Sundays. The board narrowly divided on the motion and left the question in abeyance. The Sabbath Committee responded with a pamphlet titled *Our Central Park* and with letters to the newspapers, which charged that the "continental sabbath" was infiltrating the park. New Yorkers might follow Europe in "the art of landscape gardening," but founding "a great Park, after the style of the Bois de Boulogne or the Prater" did not "carry with it the Sunday pastimes of Paris and Vienna." The sabbatarians invoked the slippery slope: "If the bars are once laid down," then it would be only a short time before the park was filled on Sundays with bands, target shooting, horse racing, prizefighting, bullfighting, gambling, fortune-telling, and "thimble-rigging."⁴¹

Although the Sabbath Committee framed its arguments in terms of morality and the "rights of peaceful, conscientious Christian citizens, and their families, to the quiet enjoyment of an enclosure they may have paid thousands to create," their opponents saw the issue in class terms. "The real object of the 'Sabbath Committee,'" the *Herald* charged, "is but a covert design to shut up the Park entirely on Sundays—to lock the gates and exclude the poor and working classes from all enjoyment within its precincts; to secure it, in short, for the 'respectable' and 'pious' portion of the community exclusively." In effect, the debate turned on the definition of the park's "public," with differing claims made by the "producing classes," who had built the park, and the tax-paying "classes who have contributed most of the money to form it."⁴²

In practical terms, the differences between the two sides were never as sharp as their rhetoric. The concrete issues remained whether the park board would allow music, boat rentals, and refreshment sales on Sundays. Perhaps because of the passions aroused, the commissioners avoided all but a few direct votes on these matters. By such evasions, they and Olmsted (even though he called himself a "Sabbath cracker") generally bent to the more politically influential

sabbatarians. No music and no boat rentals were permitted on Sundays in the 1860s. Refreshment sales were allowed; beer sales were not. Such decisions hardly closed the park on Sundays, but neither did they make it more appealing or enjoyable for the working families who had only that day on which to visit.⁴³

"The Charms of Decency and the Advantages of Order"

As the park commissioners debated what sort of park New York would have, they faced genuinely difficult choices in organizing a public ground in a diverse and democratic society. Their decisions, moreover, did not always follow rigid principle. They resisted commercialism, yet allowed restaurants and boat and carriage rental. They resisted team sports, yet allowed playing fields to be used by schoolchildren. They resisted opening the lawns but allowed people on them on Saturdays. They resisted certain activities but kept the park open on the Christian sabbath. Still, some general patterns emerged. The commission tended to favor quiet, contemplative, non-commercial, and individual or family uses of the park over boisterous and rough sports, fun and games, collectively organized amusements, and large-scale spectacles. They did permit the orchestrated socializing of the carriage parade, the band concerts, and the skating rink, but those activities could be safely organized under "respectable" auspices and posed little threat to the turf. Thus, the interests of wealthy and even middle-class New Yorkers weighed heavily in the park's initial management. Most fundamentally, the commissioners sought to separate the park clearly from the city, to make it a distinct alternative to other urban public spaces.

Policies do not, of course, determine behavior. It is one thing to announce, as Olmsted did, that "the main object" of the park was to "produce a certain influence on the minds of people," and quite another to stop the "moods and habits" of the city at the park gates. The park board never fully enforced the regime of order and decorum it desired: some visitors got drunk, ignored the rules against walking on the grass, flouted the carriage drive speed limits, scrawled or cut "names and obscene words" on benches and walls, and littered the grounds with "broken fruit, and waste of all sorts." Similarly, the city's popular and working-class cultures seeped through the gates as did workers themselves. Working-class youths irritated "respectable" skaters; flask-carrying visitors brought liquor into the park; German families set out picnics on the lawns on Sundays; elderly women sold tea and cakes without licenses.⁴⁴ Yet even the strongest challenge to the park's decorum only points up how orderly it was in the 1860s.

In the summer of 1860, a reporter for the *Express* described the edges of the park on a Sunday afternoon. At one spot near the entrance, he found "the hawkers of fruits, ballads, and exhibitions who generally locate on the verge of a populous thoroughfare," near them a Methodist tent featuring gospel singers,

religious discussions in both English and German, and missionaries distributing tracts and testaments to the surrounding crowd. "At a short distance from these, numerous motley groups had congregated at the doors and windows of the many liquor stores near the Park, drinking, smoking, lounging, and indulging in all the intoxicating 'beverages' of a gin mill." Sunday liquor laws had little effect on the operations of these saloons. "Judging from their crowded appearance," the reporter noted, "they presented more attractions to many than the park itself." Yet this lively and chaotic scene of hawkers and peddlers, gospel tents and saloons, remained squarely *outside* the park. The commission may not have been able to regulate the periphery, but it did achieve a remarkable degree of control over what went on inside. Even the borders gradually came under its influence. By the fall of 1860 (if not earlier) Olmsted and Green were pressing the police to remove the apple stands from the streets adjacent to the park. By 1867 the board of commissioners had won the right to remove any shanties, booths, or stands from walks bordering the park. The surrounding saloons gradually closed; in 1886 only about eleven of the ten thousand places licensed to sell liquor in Manhattan were on blocks facing the park.⁴⁵

The park's stone walls were a social and cultural as well as physical boundary. What most struck contemporaries about the park in the 1860s was how *different* it seemed from the city, how it presented "the very antipode of the city," as the *Times* put it in 1865. The park's propriety seemed more remarkable to many early observers than its pastoralism. "The admirable order which prevails on the Central Park," said the *Times* in a typical report, "is of itself a moral lesson and encouragement . . . in the midst of the official corruption and general municipal disarray of the times. . . . Give us at Albany, at the City Hall, at the Federal Capital, the same honest energy and discipline which have rule in the affairs of the Park, and it would soon be found that Americans are no more insensible than other people to the charms of decency and the advantages of order."⁴⁶

The *Times's* celebration of the park as an island of order in a disorderly city, as a model for the rest of society, reflected the paper's hostility to the city's political leadership. But other papers offered similar judgments. In September 1857 the *Herald*, alluding to the possibility that cockfighting, bearbaiting, and other rough sports might take over the park, was concerned that it might become "nothing but a huge bear garden for the lowest denizens of the city." Less than two years later, it found with relief that "orderly, well-conducted, and respectable" crowds refuted "the fallacious arguments of those who asserted that the Park, if ever completed, would be little better than a bear garden." Even James McCabe's 1868 guidebook, *Secrets of the Great City*, with its lurid emphasis on "the vices, the mysteries, miseries, and crimes" of New York, agreed that "there have been no acts of rowdiness or lawlessness within the enclosure, for even the most depraved feel themselves compelled to respect the rules of the place."⁴⁷

The surprisingly low level of arrests that prevailed throughout the 1860s similarly suggests few problems of misuse, misbehavior, and disorder in the park. The commissioners were probably right to boast in 1863 that "of the great numbers that visit the Park, but a very small portion require the hand of authority to check mischievous practices." Sympathetic newspapers attributed the remarkable decorum to the honesty and efficiency of the board and its employees, particularly Olmsted. Olmsted himself suggested that it reflected the tractability of Americans. "The American public," he wrote in his journal, "is one of the easiest in the world to regulate if any body will take the responsibility of regulating it." Others thought nature itself was responsible; the "humanizing influence of beauty" in Central Park, wrote one journal, works "a mysterious spell" to bring "decency and order" out of "licentiousness and confusion."⁴⁸

But these comments missed the most important (and most obvious) reason for the decorum—the dominance of elite parkgoers. Once wealthy carriage drivers learned to obey the speed limits, they seldom ran afoul of park rules or disturbed the lawns, trees, or vistas. "There is little fear that drivers will offend except in the matter of speed," Olmsted told Green in 1860.⁴⁹ And given the values they shared with the gentlemen who ran the park, rich New Yorkers who stepped out of their carriages were even less likely to offend against propriety and park rules.

But decorum and order are, after all, culturally and historically defined concepts. When mid-nineteenth-century newspaper editors and public officials talked of them, they meant bourgeois manners. From their perspective, an Irish picnic with drinking, gambling, and dancing was by definition "rowdy" and offensive, and a park that attracted the city's "best" citizens was an orderly park. Although newspaper reporters in the 1860s often celebrated Central Park as both democratic and orderly, it was precisely its lack of "democracy" that made it a park, in Olmsted's words, "properly so-called."

In the 1860s (and after) perceptions of the park were decisively shaped by the class and cultural vantage from which one evaluated it. Nothing illustrated this point better than one of the most triumphant moments in the early history of the park, when in October 1860 half a million people lined Broadway to greet the visiting Prince of Wales. A headline in the local press called it "One of the Wonderful Events of the Age." A distinguished reception committee—including the modest but ubiquitous Robert Minturn—organized an elaborate series of events to demonstrate New York's sophistication to the visiting royalty. The itinerary, of course, included a carriage drive through Central Park, where Andrew Green helped the prince plant an English oak and an American elm. This symbolic validation of the park by European royalty, the *Herald* explained, ensured that "hereafter [it] will be looked upon with still greater favor."⁵⁰ No doubt gentlemen like Robert Minturn who had found inspiration for Central Park in their trips to Europe agreed.

Many Irish-American New Yorkers did not. A weekly Irish newspaper praised the Irish-American Sixty-ninth Regiment for refusing to join the celebration. "Would it not be humiliating to them as men, as natives of Ireland, to be arrayed in the presence of a young prince, whose family has never rendered an act of Justice to Ireland?" "If the Americans forget the inhuman atrocities practiced by the great-grandfathers of this royal youth," said another paper, "are the Irish to imitate their example?" Almost twenty years later the pro-Tammany and pro-Irish *Evening Express* still remembered the prince's visit to the park as a disgraceful episode that featured "Green and the Greenswards abjectly holding the roots, while the descendant of George III, shoveled the dirt around them." For the *Express*, "the nobler picture was that of Colonel Corcoran and the Sixty-ninth regiment standing aloof and waiting for the coming war to vindicate their patriotism."⁵¹

Some park workers may have viewed that scene with the Prince of Wales with equal distaste or irony. The men who had moved 2.5 million cubic yards of stones and earth to create Central Park were lined up to watch Andrew Green, the man who had relentlessly pushed them to work harder, pick up a shovel for the first time to shift a little dirt. Meanwhile, Olmsted, the man who had not always been careful about acknowledging the work of others, complained that the designers had been ignored. "I arranged & superintended all the police arrangements," he wrote to his father, "but neither Vaux or I were taken any notice of."⁵²

In the 1860s the "gentlemen's" vision had triumphed, even if not everyone had behaved in a gentlemanly fashion. Central Park, Minturn wrote to Olmsted in 1860, "is acknowledged by everybody to be a complete success and of inestimable benefit to the city."⁵³ In the 1870s and 1880s, however, the gentlemen who governed Central Park in its first decade would face new challenges. Working-class New Yorkers who had initially stood "aloof" would begin to question the political and cultural boundaries of Minturn's notion of "everybody"—of Central Park's public.

IV. REDEFINING CENTRAL PARK



"The Rough and Ready of New York," 1888.

12

THE "MANY SIDED, FLUENT,
THOROUGHLY AMERICAN" PARK

About a year after Central Park first opened to visitors, the *Irish News* expressed its hope that "no unworthy exclusiveness shall be found operating to diminish the pleasure of the citizens in their ornamental Pleasance." But the paper added philosophically and, as it turned out, prophetically, "At all events, there will be time enough for all parties to have control over it and cherish and beautify it. Nothing here remains long in any one way. . . . We democrats have only to wait our turn."¹

Within just a decade, new "parties"—Boss Tweed and his followers—had taken control of the park, but they, too, did not remain long. During the last three decades of the nineteenth century, control of Central Park bounced from one political faction to the next. Particularly after the working-class upsurge of the mid-1880s, the definition of who constituted the public expanded; gentlemen could no longer claim a monopoly on moral and mental capital—or on the management of Central Park.

Just as post-1870 park politics could not be separated from conflicting interests in the city, so did park use mirror the changing culture of New York, with which Tweed or any other politician had relatively little to do. The move toward a more eclectic and socially diverse park started even before the Tweed Ring took power in 1870 and continued well after Boss Tweed went to jail. Moreover, the greatest impetus for change came not from the park commissioners but from below, from ordinary New Yorkers, who made their way to the park in growing numbers, transforming the social character of the crowds. In the process, they also introduced new modes of socializing that subverted the genteel decorum of the first decade, making the park more like rest of the city and, in effect, more "public."

Millions More Make the "Journey to Leisure"

The year 1870 represented something of a benchmark in the use of the park. After reaching 7.6 million in 1865, park attendance remained essentially stable for the rest of the decade, but in 1870 attendance began to climb. It rose by 16 percent that year and in 1871 by 26 percent. It leveled off again for the next three years, and after that, the gatekeepers stopped counting. One of the few available sources suggests another 40 percent increase (to 15 million people) over the next two decades or so.²

It was becoming easier to get to the park. In 1878 the Sixth Avenue elevated line shortened the "journey to leisure" by cutting twenty minutes off the streetcar trip from lower Manhattan, although initially it also doubled the price. By the end of the decade, visitors had five different horse car lines and three elevated lines to choose from. At the same time, fewer park visitors needed public transportation, for they had moved within walking distance. Every year the center of city population had edged farther uptown, and the "rural districts" had become more and more urban. In the forty years after the opening of the Central Park, Manhattan's uptown population multiplied more than seven times, three times as fast as that of the rest of the city.³

But the large jump in visitors occurred *before* the new transportation or the changes in social geography. The park began attracting wholly new constituencies. Only about one-fifth of the 2 million new visitors who came to the park in 1870 and 1871 arrived by carriage; the other four-fifths were pedestrians. The proportion of visitors on Sunday—the only day available to most working-class New Yorkers—increased, and contemporary journalists noted more working people in the park, especially on Sundays. In May 1871 the *Times* paused from its steady criticism of park management to celebrate "bright weather and cheerful scenes" in "Central Park on a May Sunday!" It reported "all kinds of people in the Sunday crowd," but "by far the majority belong to that order which is dignified . . . by manual toil."⁴

By the end of the decade, the newspaper articles on Sunday in the park carried headlines like these: "The People's Pleasure Ground," "The People's Pleasure Day," "The People's Great Playground," and "The Poor's Holiday"—the sort of terms reserved solely for the Fourth of July in the 1860s. "Eighty per cent of the visitors to the park yesterday," a reporter calculated in the spring of 1877, "were workingmen and their families." "It is chiefly the poor," said a typical article from the same period, "who, escaping from the cages in which they have been imprisoned for a week, most enjoy God's holiday on the broad walks and among the flower-fringed rambles of our beautiful Park." German Americans were singled out as the most noticeable group among the park's Sunday visitors.⁵

Unevenly rising real wages (up 50 percent overall between 1870 and 1900) enabled more working-class New Yorkers to afford the streetcars or the ele-

vated, and the eight-hour day gave many skilled workers new leisure time. Despite these gains, Sunday remained the *only* day when most working people could get to the park, some not even then. "The Central Park may do for the rich, or the humble residing within convenient distances," the *Irish Democrat* said bitterly in 1871, but for "poor families" downtown, "the brightness and beauty of the resort are as unattainable as if fifty times further removed." Two decades later in *How the Other Half Lives*, the reformer Jacob Riis noted that in one downtown public school only three of forty-eight boys had ever been to Central Park. And in 1902 an Irish immigrant maid, who lived downtown and supported a family of seven, explained to a reporter why she had never visited Central Park in her thirty years in the city: "I have never seen ten cents for carfare that wasn't needed some other way more—that's why."⁶ But if truly equal access remained illusory in an unequal society, working people in general were making more use of the park than in the past.

Easing the "Iron Rules"

As more and more working-class New Yorkers headed for the park on Sundays, some sabbatarian regulations imposed in the 1860s gave way. Boat rentals, once so hotly debated, became a regular feature of park Sundays; so did pony rides and goat carriage rides for children. The Sweeny board of the early 1870s, under constant pressure from religious groups, was still not ready to allow Sunday concerts, but even this taboo disappeared in 1877, when the board began to experiment cautiously, limiting the concerts to after 7 P.M. In 1884 the commissioners finally voted unanimously to permit regular Sunday afternoon concerts. In part, the decision reflected the waning power of sabbatarians in both local politics and the Protestant church. For example, Henry Ward Beecher, still a popular and respected minister despite the charges of adultery leveled against him in a lurid trial nine years before, told a reporter in 1884 that he found "no harm" in a Sunday afternoon park concert as long as park commissioners prevented drinking and rowdyism.⁷

The concert decision also stemmed from the altered politics of the park board and the city. Park boards of the last three decades of the nineteenth century never represented working-class interests or priorities in any direct way, but as appointees of a popularly elected mayor rather than members of a self-perpetuating board, commissioners now responded to local political pressures. In what the *Times* called the "Sunday concert war," some commissioners weighed the consequences of their park policies against electoral votes rather than the prestige of the people on the two sides. Commissioner Egbert Viele, a Democratic party activist, led the fight on the board for Sunday concerts. His impending campaign for Congress no doubt made him particularly sensitive to public opinion. Commissioner John Crimmins supported him on the issue. "As

a contractor, I employ large numbers of men. . . . These are some of the people who will be attracted Sundays," since they "have not time" or are "too tired" to attend Saturday concerts. The Central Labor Union and the Clothing Cutters' Union passed resolutions, local cigar factories circulated petitions, and Catholic priests preached sermons for Sunday concerts. German Americans, a growing voting bloc that included Protestants, Catholics, and Jews, mobilized against what they called the "fanatics" and "hypocrites" of the Sabbath Committee. When sixty thousand people showed up for the first Sunday afternoon program, the board was deeply impressed.⁸

The *Times* said the commissioners' vote for the Sunday concerts showed "a proper appreciation of the needs of the general public," but what was really at stake was an expanded definition of "the general public." The *Times* itself contributed to this redefinition as applied to Central Park when its editors sent reporters to Catholic priests and labor leaders for comments. Twenty-five years earlier, when the *Times* had explicitly warned the park commissioners not to heed unnamed and unquoted "vulgar agitators," such voices had been largely ignored in public debates on the nature of the park. Now, the *Times* embraced and promoted the continental Sabbath.⁹ In an era of sharp labor conflict, Sunday park concerts had come to seem less threatening to social order than Sunday "idleness" in the corner saloon or radical political agitation. Better Sunday concerts on the Mall than Henry George in City Hall.

The *Staats-Zeitung* reported that working people made up the vast majority of Sunday concert crowds, creating "a completely different picture" from that of the "better society . . . in their velvet and silk" who attended the Saturday concerts. There were many working-class women: "Two-thirds of the crowd at Central Park yesterday afternoon wore white dresses," the *World* reported of an 1884 Sunday concert. "There was the usual complement of men in uncomfortable looking clothing, but they were in the microscopic minority. Even the babies outnumbered them three to one and the girls outnumbered the babies in almost as large proportion."¹⁰

The *Times*—emphasizing the presence of working-class families as well as unaccompanied women—described the first concerts in the park as "a great big labor-union picnic." "The masses who slave from daylight till dark six days in the week" filled the air with the "babel of tongues." The only middle-class New Yorkers the reporter spotted in the throng were "a few eminently respectable men of middle age, who hung on the outer edges of the multitude" and "wished it distinctly understood that they were in no way part or parcel of the crowd." They "were attracted merely by a curiosity to see how the common people behaved." They found, to the surprise of many officials and reporters, that they behaved very well. Twenty years earlier Central Park had been the place to watch the elite on parade; now, at least on a summer Sunday, it was a place to see "how the other half lived."¹¹

"Dear me, this is quite as good as going to Coney Island!" a *Herald* reporter



In the 1880s working-class New Yorkers successfully campaigned for band concerts in Central Park on Sundays, their only day of rest.

heard a young woman say as she "emerged hot and rumped from the crush." A laborer who worked fourteen hours a day in a gashouse said the concert was "the only real pleasurable Sunday I have enjoyed in ten years." He told the *World* that he had "never heard of the Park until of the music, and to-day I have been as happy as a king." After the first month of Sunday afternoon concerts, the *World* wrote that "the crowds have learned more about the Park and instead of remaining as heretofore close to the [bandstand] . . . they scattered all over the great pleasure ground, every seat from the ramble to the reservoir harboring at least one couple."¹²

Families in trade wagons joined the concert crowds on Sundays. By the 1870s gatekeepers no longer vigilantly barred commercial vehicles on Sundays. Newspaper accounts include descriptions of the "modest wagon in which the

good man had peddled his wares during the week, and which is now furbished up and gay with the joyous smiles of a happy household." On weekdays, the fashionable carriage parade continued in full force, but on Sundays the "German provision man" out with "his family for a drive in a heavy old wagon" and the "ambitious persons of small means" in hired vehicles took over the carriage drives.¹³

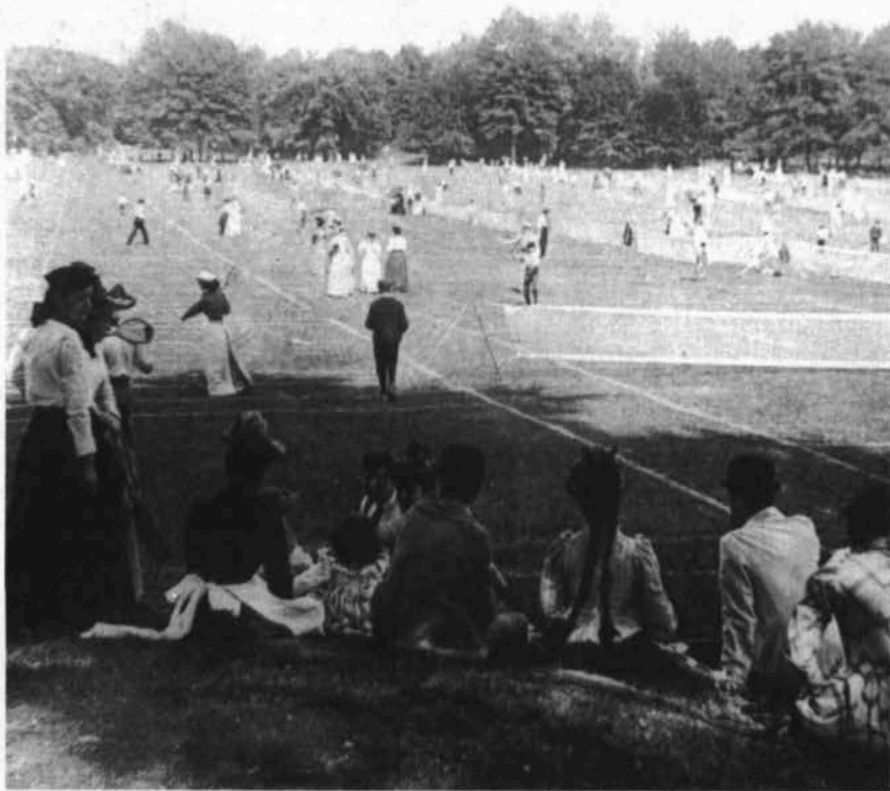
The loosening of Sunday park rules prompted park commissioner Matthew Borden (a distant relative of the infamous Lizzie and the sort of Republican Yankee merchant who might have sat on the original board) to complain that the park was turning into a "circus ground." He sought a Sunday ban on the use of swings, goat rides, sailing boats, and the Carousel. But Borden was now an anomaly on the board. Crimmins allied with his fellow board member and business associate Henry Beekman, a politically active lawyer and real estate man, to defeat his proposal.¹⁴

While sabbatarians and antisabbatarians fought over use of the park on a particular day of the week, other skirmishes centered on use of particular areas of the park, especially its lawns. The Sweeny board responded to pressure for more space for active sports by opening part of the North Meadow between 97th and 102nd streets to baseball, though it still refused calls to allow working men and youths as well as schoolboys to play the national game. "I do not think it just to our class," the president of a team of "working boys," complained about the policy. Nevertheless, the official ban on adult baseball games remained in place until the 1920s.¹⁵

Still, resistance to other sports in the park, particularly those that reflected the growing middle-class enthusiasm for competitive games and "strenuous living," weakened. In the 1880s the commissioners began to permit archery, lacrosse, football, and tennis on lawns, roller skating on paths, and bicycling (with some restrictions) on the drives. Tennis, first permitted in 1884 with temporary nets on the South Meadow just below 97th Street on the park's western side (the site of the present-day tennis courts), was particularly popular with both middle- and upper-class New Yorkers. By 1892 there were 125 grass courts in the upper park, though all who used the courts had to get permits.¹⁶

The longtime concern about the condition of the lawns continued, but the "keep off the grass" regulations aroused constant protest. The newspapers denounced "iron rules" that made the lawns "meadows only in name," "panoramic beauties to be gazed upon but not enjoyed." Even the *New York Times*, which had faithfully supported park regulations in the 1860s, complained in an 1875 editorial: "The rules about not walking upon the grass are now enforced so rigidly that sending children to the Park is rather a punishment for them than a treat."¹⁷

But the rules were not always enforced so rigidly. A park visitor in 1873 saw "dozens of people in a single place, coolly ignoring the notice, 'Please keep off the grass,'" and particularly on warm Sundays, the huge crowds overflowed the



When tennis became a popular new sport among wealthy and middle-class New Yorkers in the 1880s, the park commission set up courts on the meadows north of the reservoir. The first paved courts were constructed in 1912.

paths onto the lawns. At a Sunday concert attended by sixty thousand people in 1884, the *Times* observed, "'Please keep off the grass' was unheeded."¹⁸

In 1875 Olmsted urged that the baseball grounds be closed for the year, but politically minded commissioners refused to go along. Whether schoolboys could continue to use the lawns had "long agitated the deliberations of the Park Commission," the *Herald* explained. Commissioners "who wished to become popular earnestly advocated granting the privilege while those who cared more for the beauty of the Park than for the applause of the people as earnestly resisted the demand."¹⁹

The vacillation continued throughout the nineteenth century: commissioners loosened restrictions and enforcement, then tightened them again. But the general direction was toward relaxing the originally rigid policy. By the 1880s most of the lawns were designated by a blue pennant with white stars as "common" (or open) on Sunday. Permits were also granted for children's (but

not workers') May Day picnics on park meadows. Policies varied, however, by time and place. It took a rather large red sign to explain the rules for use of the Green (Sheep Meadow):

Whenever the turf of the green is not specifically unfit for use, permission will be given to certified members of the public schools, under 16 years of age, for ball-playing upon it on Saturdays. It will be open for croquet-playing Mondays, Wednesdays, and Fridays for ladies and gentlemen. It will be open to the public in general on Sunday. A red flag on the staff will indicate that the green is closed. A blue flag with white ball that it is open for the ball-players; a white flag with red ball that it is open for the croquet-players; a blue pennant with white stars that it is 'common,' or open to the public in general.²⁰

By the 1890s pressure was growing to eliminate the keep-off-the-grass regulations entirely. In 1895 the commission briefly removed most of the signs, only to return them when intensive use made the lawns look "like vacant lots in a tenement house district." Two years later, the president of the park board again "called in or overruled every 'Keep Off the Grass' sign in the city." "This may offend artists and landscape architects," a "philosophical park policeman" observed, "but, after all, it is the way parks should be used."²¹

Still, even under the most liberal regimes, many of the familiar activities of ethnic and working-class picnics were prohibited. In 1895 a British visitor praised park officials for not giving in to "the multitude who cannot dissociate beer and skittles from their conception of bliss." In 1881 park officials did allow a procession from the Società Mazzini, which was headed for the statue of Italian nationalist leader Giuseppe Mazzini (near 67th Street on the park's west side), but on the condition that they "remove the little flags from the horses' heads and lower the flags carried in the carriages." "The lowering of the flags," one member protested, "made the procession not a procession." The next year, the society's members simply decorated the statue quietly and then went off to Wendell's Elm Park at 92nd Street and Ninth Avenue to have "a good time." Most ethnic associations, churches, and trade unions continued to hold their festivals at commercially run picnic grounds such as Elm Park, Jones Wood, and Sulzer's Harlem River Park.²²

The *Times* may have described the first Sunday afternoon concert as resembling "a great big labor-union picnic," but labor picnics usually included speeches, beer kegs, dancing, sports, and games of chance—none of which were officially permitted in Central Park. Therefore, after the nation's first Labor Day parade in 1882, festivities were scheduled for Elm Park. Some less official labor gatherings do seem to have escaped the notice of Central Park officials. In the 1880s, as cloakmaker Abraham Rosenberg later recalled, garment workers unhappy with piecework rates would stop work for the day and "go off to a picnic to 'Cendele' (Central) Park," where their employers "would know where to look for them."²³

But Central Park rarely—if ever—served as a space for overt political mobilization. Instead, rallies took place at Tompkins Square (site of the 1874 unemployed demonstrations and the 1877 rally in support of the nationwide railroad strikes), Union Square (gathering spot for the first Labor Day parade), or City Hall Park. In 1886 Henry George took his campaign to the docks, factory yards, elevated stations, commercial picnic grounds, street corners, and Tompkins and Union squares—but not to Central Park. Park officials were, however, willing to provide a forum for presidents, mayors, and other political leaders at ceremonial dedications of statues and museums—political uses of the park that posed no threat.²⁴

Rides and Restaurants

The park commissioners resisted many of the commercial enterprises that solicited a place in the park. Nevertheless, some of the barriers against these "intrusions" came down and parkgoers began to encounter new amusements that resembled the attractions of the commercial entertainment world. From the opening of the park, the board had debated how much of the marketplace to allow in. Even before the Sweeny board took power, Andrew Green (whose eye never wandered far from the bottom line) saw franchise fees as a means of raising park maintenance funds. By the end of the 1860s the board was giving out licenses to entrepreneurs to operate boats (sixty cents an hour), carriages (twenty-five cents for a ride around the park), wheelchairs (fifty cents an hour with an attendant), a goat cart on the Mall (ten cents), and a photo house that snapped and sold pictures. Plans for a children's carousel south of the 65th Street Transverse Road were carried to completion under Sweeny.²⁵

Both before and after 1870 the park board tended to be more indulgent of commercial attractions in the park if children were the primary beneficiaries. The popular Carousel (ten cents), which was turned by a blind mule and a horse kept in the basement and instructed by one or two stomps on the floor above, boosted park attendance in 1870 and 1871. In 1874 John Lucas was granted permission to operate a donkey ride (ten cents) for children between the Bow Bridge and Vista Rock. The following year, pony rides (ten cents) were added.²⁶

The charges for "the go-carts, the ponies, the hobby horses, and the boats," a reporter noted during the depression of the 1870s, "are above a poor man's means. . . . Ten cents is asked a child for a ride . . . , while many of the fathers of the children . . . are glad during the week to get work at 12 cents an hour." Poor children, indeed, were more likely to be the purveyors of commercial goods and services than their consumers. They led the goat carts, for example, and in the 1890s immigrant East Side and Yorkville youths—including future movie mogul William Fox and future U.S. senator Robert F. Wagner—regularly sold candy in the park despite the long-standing ban on peddling and hawking.²⁷



Children were both the workers and the customers for goat rides on the Mall.

Commercialization thus reinforced class distinctions among children as among adults.

By the late 1860s officials allowed four permanent refreshment spots in the park: the Casino east of the Mall; a small refreshment stand under the Terrace; Mount St. Vincent (the old convent building, now converted into a restaurant); and the Mineral Springs Pavilion (located at the northwest corner of the Sheep Meadow). In 1871 the Dairy (in the lower park) was completed and temporarily turned into another eating place rather than the milk dispensary the designers had planned as the center of what came to be called the Children's District. In the early 1870s, Mount St. Vincent and the Casino were renovated and expanded, and increasingly served only the park's wealthiest visitors. Both offered easy access for carriages. An 1877 guidebook described Mount St. Vincent as "the focal point where the Drives and Bridle Roads and the Park Carriage Route terminate." This terminus was a favorite stopping point for sleighs, carriages, and riding parties and for Coaching Club excursions headed for upper Manhattan.²⁸

Describing Mount St. Vincent's "cozy little parlor, with its rich crimson plush drapings and furniture" and its wealthy patrons, a *Times* reporter observed that "many of the armchairs . . . were occupied by portly gentlemen who own good horses, keep good bank accounts, and who know what real comfort is." Another reporter called it the "favored resort of those who have more greenbacks than brains." Particularly in the evening, it acquired a reputation as a gathering place for the city's male sporting crowd, for rich horse fanciers like

August Belmont and William H. Vanderbilt, as well as Tammany politicians, and "men about town." That reputation grew after 1883 when Mount St. Vincent was rebuilt after a fire and came under the management of Patrick McCann, brother-in-law of Tammany kingpin (and former park dweller) Richard Croker. The Sisters of Charity asked that their name no longer be used in conjunction with a place that had come to seem morally suspect, and it reclaimed its eighteenth-century designation as McGown's Pass Tavern.²⁹

The Dairy served ice cream, sandwiches, pastry, ale, porter, and coffee and attracted, the *Times* wrote, people of "more modest desires"—and means. Still, it was far from cheap. A *Herald* reporter protested that the coffee, at ten cents, was double the downtown price, and Bass ale at thirty-five cents was ten cents more than the tariff at the city's bars. Prices and customers varied with the restaurant. According to the *Herald* reporter, "Ice cream from the same freezers" cost fifteen cents at the Dairy and the Terrace, twenty cents at the Casino, and twenty-five cents at Mount St. Vincent.³⁰

This market segmentation simply reproduced the restaurant practices of the city. Still, some observers pointed up the contradiction posed by such class-based segregation within a public park. "In this . . . garden of pleasure and recreation for our citizens," West Sider Lloyd T. Seaman told the park commission in 1891, "there have been provided three restaurants—McGown's Pass Tavern, the Casino, and the Dairy—in all of which refreshment is provided for the rich and middle classes, but none for either the poor or the very poor."³¹ The two expensive and, hence, exclusive restaurants provided a place for wealthy and middle-class New Yorkers within a park they no longer controlled, a form of class insulation in an increasingly heterogeneous public space.

The availability of lager beer for five cents at the Terrace brought in some visitors (particularly German Americans) who might otherwise have spent their Sunday at a commercial beer garden. And while ten cents for a goat-cart ride probably stretched the pocketbook of an unskilled laboring family, it was not out of the reach of skilled working families, particularly by the 1880s. Moreover, in 1877 the park board's prolabor and Tammany-allied president, William R. Martin, cut the fee on the Carousel from ten cents to five. Even for laboring families, then, a trip to the park with its free zoo and its modestly priced rides was one of the cheapest ways to enjoy commercial entertainment on a special occasion. "A trip to Central Park, with a ride in the goat wagon, was something that came to you on your birthday if you were lucky," Al Smith recalled of his childhood on the Lower East Side in the early 1880s.³²

The "Relapse into Barbarism"

In October 1872 Olmsted complained to the board that "the park is much misused," compared to the early days, when "a lawless habit was rare among visitors." The villain in this decline was obvious: the Sweeny board, which,



NEW YORK CITY.—THE STUDY OF BOTANY UNDER DIFFICULTIES.—A SCENE ON A BY-PATH IN CENTRAL PARK.

The park police were not always successful in enforcing rules against picking ferns and flowers.

"indifferent to the danger," had allowed the park keepers' discipline to lapse. But Olmsted acknowledged a broader cause for the changed behavior of parkgoers. "It was to be expected," he told the board, "as the city should in effect be brought nearer, year by year, to the park, and it thus came to be more easily, familiarly and numerous visited, that the means used for instructing and reminding visitors of their duty would be found less effective."³³

Olmsted's perception of a loss of manners reflected, in part, the increase in the numbers of working-class visitors, who did not necessarily follow the prescribed codes of bourgeois gentility, and also, in part, the changing behavior of middle-class New Yorkers, who had themselves begun to question "proper" park decorum. Although there is no easy way to untangle the perception of increased disorder or crime from the reality of changing public behavior, newspaper accounts of the late nineteenth century do provide overwhelming evidence of growing concern about improper conduct in the park. Papers that in the 1860s had praised the park's orderliness, now lamented its "relapse into barbarism." News articles complained most frequently about the relatively innocent act of picking flowers or ferns or breaking off branches of lilacs or rhododendrons. Press accounts were often vague or contradictory on the identity of the guilty parties. Sometimes, the culprits seem to have been well-to-



The 1869 dedication of the monument to the German naturalist Alexander von Humboldt. By the 1870s visitors could admire twenty-four statues, most donated by ethnic associations and private benefactors. Olmsted worried that the enormous crowds that turned out for the dedications would trample the landscape.

do—"neatly dressed boys" or "charming young girls." Yet the newspapers also blamed "loafers" or "evil disposed persons." New parkgoers may have seen little wrong in picking flowers in a park. Patrons of uptown barrooms who openly took rhododendrons from the park to decorate their favorite saloons may not have believed that they were violating any laws or ethical standards.³⁴

When big crowds gathered, the problems loomed particularly large—at least to Olmsted. On May 15, 1877, a record-breaking crowd turned out to see President Rutherford B. Hayes dedicate a statue to the Knickerbocker poet Fitz-Greene Halleck. The dedication went smoothly, according to press accounts. A school principal, James Herbert Morse, noted in his diary the "picturesque beauty" of the crowd. But Olmsted angrily called it "*essentially a mob, lawless and uncontrollable*." He was outraged not simply by the sight of "women and girls breaking off branches of lilacs" or others "trampling over shrubs and vines" but because the offenders "seemed surprised" when he confronted them with their transgressions. On another occasion, in 1875, Olmsted had been equally distressed to encounter between fifty and two hundred "rude fellows" "beyond the school age" playing ball in the park.³⁵

Olmsted did not specify the class of these "rude fellows," but other observers saw rowdy behavior as endemic to the immigrant working class. "The

rich as a general thing know how to behave themselves," explained a letter to the *Sun* in 1871, "but unfortunately the poor boys, at least those whom I have seen on the playgrounds, manifest a strong propensity to devilry and cannot control themselves, being invariably very boisterous and rowdy in their activities." But not only working-class men and boys defied park rules. The *Times* in an 1895 story complained that the "young women were worse than the men"; "their sport" involved tossing around "handkerchief balls" stuffed with grass "obtained by tearing it up by the roots from the lawns."³⁶

Some observers were distressed at the growing indifference to official park regulations among both middle- and working-class users. Others were unhappy over transgressions of etiquette enshrined in manners handbooks rather than the park rule book. In mid-1873 Jan Vier wrote a series of letters to the *Tribune* warning of an "increased tendency to disorder" in the park. "A couple near an open, frequented walk" had particularly offended Vier when he saw them "caressing each other under an umbrella in a way fit only for strict privacy." Vier's condemnation rested on bourgeois standards of conduct that proscribed displays of intimacy and affection. Yet those standards no longer governed public behavior as strictly as they once had. Indeed, Vier could be accused of violating a basic rule of etiquette. The "essence of true politeness," said *The Illustrated Manners Book*, is "in the homely maxim, 'MIND YOUR OWN BUSINESS.'"³⁷

Courting had long been a part of the park scene, but nineteenth-century observers noted with increasing frequency that the park had become a "trysting place" for "young people who work in the factories and shops." One contributor to the *Herald's* "complaint book" thought "scandalous and objectionable conduct" in Central Park (of a sort "not fit to be mentioned in the *Herald* or any other respectable journal") reflected poorly on "the influence of a Christian City." A less puritanical letter writer, however, saw nothing very shocking about courting in the park; the young couples who "belong to the working classes . . . have no homes in which to make love, so they are compelled to make a public exhibition of themselves."³⁸

Working-class couples valued the freedom that the park offered from the watchful eyes of parents. One report on an early Sunday concert observed that a mechanic's sixteen-year-old daughter and her friend from the upstairs tenement had "at the first opportunity slip[ped] away to mingle in the crowd and pick up more congenial companions from the male friends they [were] . . . sure to find." Nor was the appeal of Central Park as a place of assignation confined to mechanics' daughters. In *The Custom of the Country*, Edith Wharton located an illicit meeting of a social-climbing young woman in the Wisteria Arbor. "The habit of meeting young men in sequestered spots was not unknown to her," Wharton wrote. Young middle- and upper-class women, who were expected to have chaperones in other settings, could meet suitors much more freely in the "protected" park.³⁹

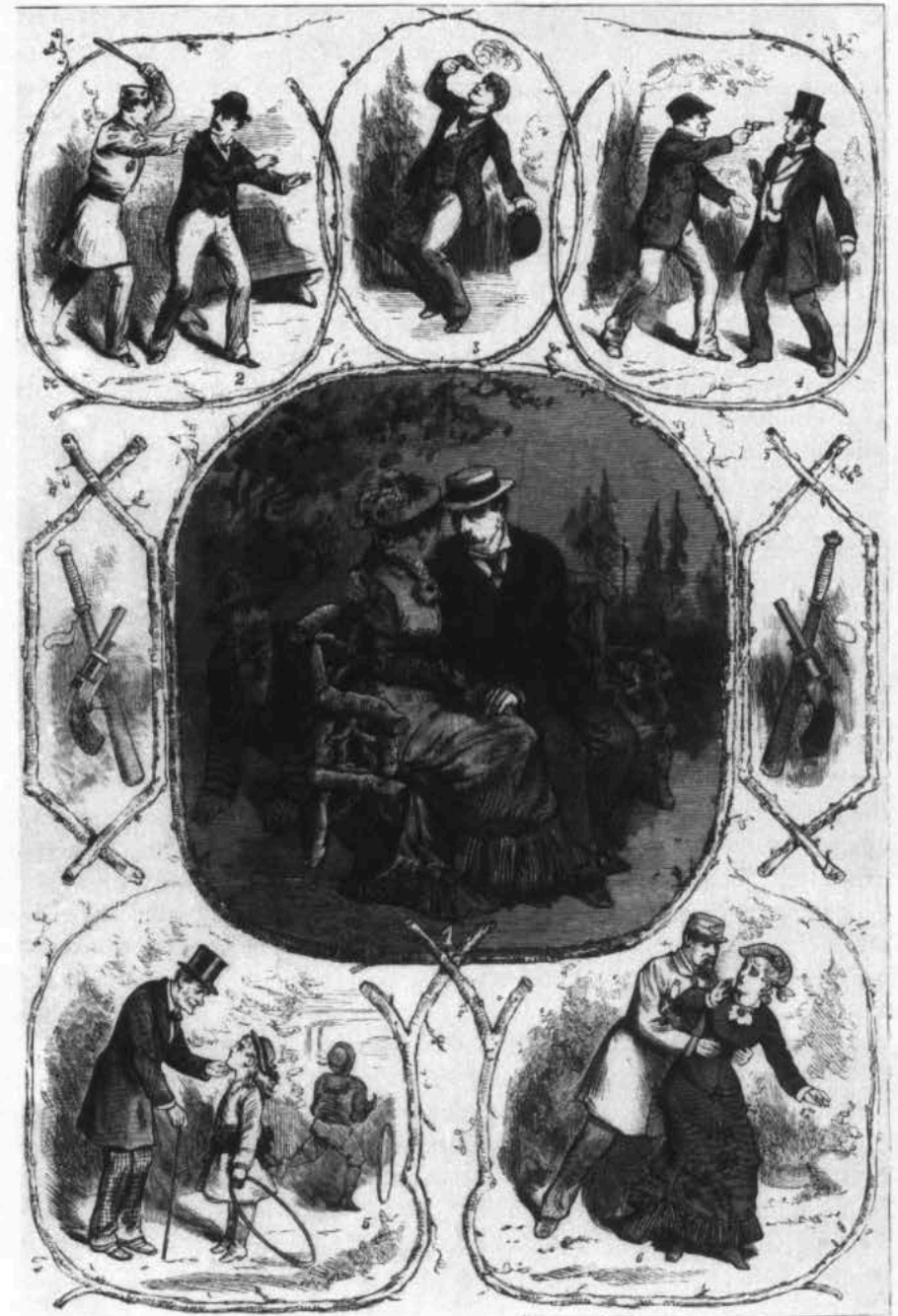
But where women found freedom, some male observers sensed danger. Vier denounced the "horrible indecencies perpetrated after nightfall" in the park: "Many a servant maid and shop girl comes in virtuous and goes away ruined, for it is notorious that the Park is now more than ever a favorite and fruitful resort for the pimp and seducer." Curious about the validity of such charges, Joseph Pulitzer's *World* assigned its crack female reporter to investigate. Elizabeth Cochrane (who wrote as Nellie Bly) had made a speciality of going undercover to expose iniquities of big city life. She had revealed the cruel treatment of women prisoners and of sweatshop workers. Her most famous exploit was her 1889 besting of the "around-the-world-in-eighty-days" record of Jules Verne's fictional hero Phineas Fogg. In the summer of 1888 Cochrane disguised herself as a "country girl" to uncover what she called "the infamy of the park"—the wiles of a wicked stable foreman who drove a carriage through the park daily, picking up women and enticing them into prostitution.⁴⁰

The sensational *National Police Gazette* also wrote luridly of the "perils of the park," which included "murderous attacks upon the chastity of pure-minded young females"—apparently a reference to men exposing themselves. The *Police Gazette* was especially distressed that this "crime of a most revolting nature has left its ordinary haunts in some of the streets and byways of the city and established its headquarters in Central Park."⁴¹

The fragmentary police records of the period bear out to some extent the *Gazette's* alarm over new sexual behavior and assaults in the park. In the 1860s crimes relating to "decency," or sexuality, did not even rate a separate listing in the park arrest statistics, although a few such arrests may have been counted among the "other offenses." By the late 1870s and the 1880s, "indecent exposure," "indecent conduct," "indecent assault," "crime against nature," "cohabiting," "sodomy," "attempted rape," and "rape" all appeared in the arrest classification scheme. Still, the arrest levels for such crimes were considerably lower than the sensational coverage would suggest. They accounted for fewer than 6 percent of arrests in all city parks between 1879 and 1886; in those same years, only one man was arrested for rape in a city park.⁴²

Prostitution, illicit sexuality, and violence against women were far from unusual in late nineteenth-century New York, but as far as we can tell, the demimonde flourished in downtown streets, saloons, and brothels, not in up-town parks. And—as is true today—women faced as much danger from assault by their husbands and others in their homes as by strangers in the parks. Perhaps Central Park's only attempted murder in the 1880s was Bertram Rodway's shooting of his estranged wife in the bushes near the southwestern Playground.⁴³

If "public" threats in the park were less grave than newspaper reports implied, why was there so much talk about peril? Was Central Park "no longer a safe place for women and children"? Editors expected Central Park, unlike the city, to be free of crime. Moreover, journalists recognized the public fascination



"Perils of the Park": In 1878 the *Police Gazette* published the lurid warning that visitors were no longer safe in Central Park.

with the seeming paradox of urban dangers lurking in a pastoral pleasure ground. In 1872 when an out-of-town-visitor became the first person murdered in the course of a robbery in the park, the *Times* mourned that "murder has actually stained the turf of that green fairy land." The *Police Gazette* similarly headlined its first article on the "perils of the park": "How Our Beautiful City Resort Is Polluted by Foul Tidings in Human Form."⁴⁴

But the intense focus in these accounts on the dangers faced by women and the language used to express those fears lead one to suspect that the concern was as much *about* women as *for* them. Reporters and editors may have been reflecting a deeper anxiety about changing relations between the sexes. In the early 1870s, when public fears about women's safety in the parks were particularly strong, feminists were strongly pressing their demands for equality. The feminist newspapers *Revolution* and *Woodhull and Claflin's Weekly* (both published in New York City) raised the banner of equal rights for women and also challenged traditional male prerogatives in their advocacy of "free love," by which they meant equality for women and men in sexual relations.⁴⁵ In the context of this sharp challenge to the traditional gender hierarchy, talk about "protecting" women may be understood as insistence that women were not, in fact, equal, that they were dependent on men for their well-being and their physical safety.

Newspaper accounts repeatedly and paternalistically pointed to women as vulnerable when they were *alone*. "It is now disagreeable," observed an 1872 *Times* editorial, for "women to enter the Park in the daytime unaccompanied by a man." Six years later, a local judge explained that "ruffians" never "insult respectable females" *except* "when they are unprotected. They know too well the consequences of such an act if discovered by a male friend or escort."⁴⁶

Such comments may have exaggerated the danger, but they did accurately reflect a growing tendency of women to visit the park without male companions. Women were increasingly taking the reins of park carriages themselves and leaving even the coachman at home. And small groups of women could be found riding horses together in the early morning without an accompanying "riding master." By 1891 a local carriage industry journal was grumbling about "the somewhat dangerous nature of the driving of women in Central Park" in terms that prefigured later complaints about women car drivers.⁴⁷

The bicycle craze of the late 1880s and the 1890s most dramatically expanded the ability of women to propel themselves independently through the park. Marie E. Ward, who had ridden the carriage drives with her grandmother Abby Hall Ward back in the 1870s, announced in *Bicycling for Ladies* (1896) that "the bicycle supplies . . . a new pleasure—the pleasure of going where one wills, because one wills. . . . Riding the wheel, our own powers are revealed to us. . . . You have conquered a new world, and exultingly you take possession of it." Women cyclists could transform themselves from the driven to the drivers,



In the 1890s the "new woman" could pursue sports like tennis and bicycling in the park. "The bicycle supplies . . . a new pleasure," Marie E. Ward declared, "the pleasure of going where one wills, because one wills."

particularly if they donned "sensible" costumes that gave them greater freedom of movement. To Annie Nathan Meyer, a feminist (and also an antisuffragist), a "wheel-woman" (whose face was "crimson with exertion . . . her suit . . . about as unbecoming as genius could make it") made a much more appealing figure than a fashion-conscious woman in a park carriage ("perfectly gowned" with cheeks "as smooth as cream . . . can make them"). Meyer recalled the "exhilaration" and "the sensation of rapturous freedom" of having been the first woman to use the park tennis courts in the mid-1880s. But she objected that the freer mixing of men and women in sports in the park of the 1890s was simply reinforcing older patterns. She lamented the loss of an earlier sense of nonconformity. "Now that society applauds the 'out-of-door girl,' that delicious sense

of overtopping the rest of the world, of looking down upon the unhappy, conventional ones is gone."⁴⁸

On occasion, the question of single-sex recreation sparked controversy. When the croquet fields temporarily closed in 1877, women apparently were divided over whether men should be allowed when the fields reopened. One woman urged "girls who love the game" to "compel" the park commissioners "to return to us what long possession has made us consider our right." Other New Yorkers believed that women and men should be able to play together. The croquet fields reopened to men as well as women, and the segregation of facilities by sex within the park gradually gave way to new patterns of mixed socializing. By 1891 the tennis tournaments included ladies-singles but also mixed-doubles competitions.⁴⁹

As new patterns of behavior and use became possible, some women demanded access to park facilities and a number also wrote to the mayor to protest "nuisances" in the park, from manure piles to unlighted paths. Without the right to vote, they could not fully claim their rights as members of the political public, but through their clubs and civic associations they participated in debates over park policy. Still, it would take almost a century for the prophecy of the women's rights activist who clashed with the board in 1893 to be fulfilled. "The day was coming," she said, "when women would have their rights, and when women would sit on the park board."⁵⁰

"Tramps and Other Unpleasant People"

Whatever uneasiness assertive and independent women generated in using the park in the late nineteenth century, most New York men accepted (indeed welcomed) their presence. Similarly, while some may have complained that working-class visitors did not know how to "behave themselves," working-class New Yorkers became a familiar part of the park's public in these years. But that public, though expanded, had its outer boundaries.

For many parkgoers the arrival of the nineteenth-century equivalent of "street people"—tramps and homeless women—marked decline rather than "opening up." Reports of "tramps" in the park increased markedly in the mid-1870s, when the depression threw thousands out of work (and indeed, the word came into currency as a disparaging description of men without jobs or homes). At least some of the unemployed found the park a pleasant place to sleep, to pass the day, or perhaps even to do some panhandling. "Tramps," *New York by Sunlight and Gaslight* noted in 1882, treat Central Park as "a favorite lodging-place . . . in warm weather."⁵¹

Some New Yorkers without homes claimed the park as a place to live; others without jobs claimed it as a place to earn money on their own. Driving through the park in April 1887 one parkgoer "saw as many as 15 to 20 men, women and



This montage, "The Tramp Nuisance: Birds of Passage and Their Roosts in the City Parks," appeared in the *New York Daily Graphic* in 1888.

boys, digging dandelions." The police pursued the culprits, but some continued to eke out a living by selling dandelion greens to vegetable dealers for ten cents a quart. (Like so many park rules, this one was enforced selectively. Ethel Dana, daughter of a well-to-do Episcopal clergyman, often picked dandelions in the park without police interference.)⁵²

Many middle-class parkgoers found contact with the homeless and the jobless disturbing. "Tramps and other unpleasant people," the *Tribune* commented with disdain in May 1877, have "quit their Winter quarters for the benches in the Park. These persons are often an annoyance and prevent much enjoyment in the secluded walks. Ladies and children hesitate to venture into the Ramble without escorts." Contrary to the *Tribune's* implication, most unemployed men who were spending their days in the park did not insult women or molest children. The article contains a detail that reveals much about the true nature of the threat. With some puzzlement, the reporter observed that nannies "are the only ones who seem to be perfectly at ease and never timid" when facing the "tramps." Perhaps it was because these women also came from a similar class background. Poor women themselves, moreover, constituted about one-fifth of parkgoers arrested for vagrancy.⁵³

Some commentators more frankly acknowledged what was at stake in the growing heterogeneity of the city's public spaces. Finding park seats and benches occupied by "ragged and vicious tramps" or people of "a class just above begging and vagabondage," who "smoke their rank pipes" and "eject their filthy tobacco-juice," *Appleton's Journal* recommended the immediate removal of "the free seats" and the substitution of "chairs at a small charge, after the custom generally adopted in Europe." *Appleton's* allowed that the "idea of perfect democracy in our public places is no doubt very fine in theory," but "true democracy has its limitations—it does not give any one the privilege to be as filthy as he pleases, as disgusting in his habits as he likes, or as worthless as he chooses." The park is for "that large, respectable mass of people," who are prepared to treat it as "a sort of public parlor" and "not for vagabonds—a class who have no rights that anybody is called upon to consider or respect."⁵⁴

This effort to define "vagabonds" as outside the park's proper cultural public in effect paralleled the Tilden Commission's attempt two years later to define propertyless New Yorkers as outside the political public altogether. Neither succeeded in narrowing the public. Yet the park board did instruct its police force to maintain limitations on what *Appleton's* called "perfect democracy." Later in the century, park police continued to use their arrest powers to exclude certain kinds of people and prohibit certain kinds of behavior as unacceptable in the park. Acknowledging the "necessity" of "police regulations and police men," park police captain Henry Koster reasoned that "civilization has not yet invented a patent to make homogeneous the inclination, manners and action of an incongruous people."⁵⁵

By the late 1880s park police were apparently arresting five times as many

people as they had in the 1860s. Few of those arrests involved crimes against people (e.g., assault) or against property (e.g., robbery or picking pockets). In 1886 more than 90 percent targeted some form of improper behavior, primarily disorderly conduct, drunkenness, vagrancy, or violations of park ordinances. Park regulations in the early 1870s permitted the police to remove "filthy or offensive persons"—a provision that no one had thought necessary when the park first opened. Improper conduct had been the basis of most park arrests in the 1860s as well, but neither drunkenness nor vagrancy had rated a separate arrest classification then, and "fast driving" accounted for almost half of all arrests. Twenty years later, the comparable category ("reckless driving") made up less than 3 percent of park arrests. Park crime, like park use, had moved down the social scale, with the city's poorest and least respectable citizens (tramps and prostitutes, for example) most likely to encounter police harassment.⁵⁶

The growing level of arrests as well as heightened alarm in the press about various forms of park misbehavior (from courting to sleeping on benches) should not lead us to think that crime or disorder overran Central Park. "Tramps" were ubiquitous in the depression-shrouded New York of the late nineteenth century, but there were probably fewer in Central Park than elsewhere in the city. Similarly, Olmsted was shocked to find "prostitutes . . . seeking their prey without hindrance" in "the most secluded and sylvan districts" of the park, but they plied their trade with a great deal less harassment by the police on downtown streets. The park remained a much more orderly and serene public place than the city streets, the commercial pleasure grounds, or the downtown squares. "You cannot anywhere get away from the misery of life" in New York City, William Dean Howells wrote in his 1896 essay "Glimpses of Central Park." Still, he would rather "walk in the pathways of the Park than in the streets of the city, for the contrasts there are not so frequent, if they are glaring still."⁵⁷

Pluralism in Bronze

The Central Park landscape began to display new material evidence of heterogeneity as well. The entrants in the original design competition for the park—though not the winners Vaux and Olmsted—had recognized the appeal within the natural landscape of statues, a common feature of the city's pleasure gardens and European parks.⁵⁸ But as new groups brought eclectic tastes to the park, some New Yorkers mobilized to block the proliferating statuary, which they believed undercut the designers' goals in creating a pastoral park.

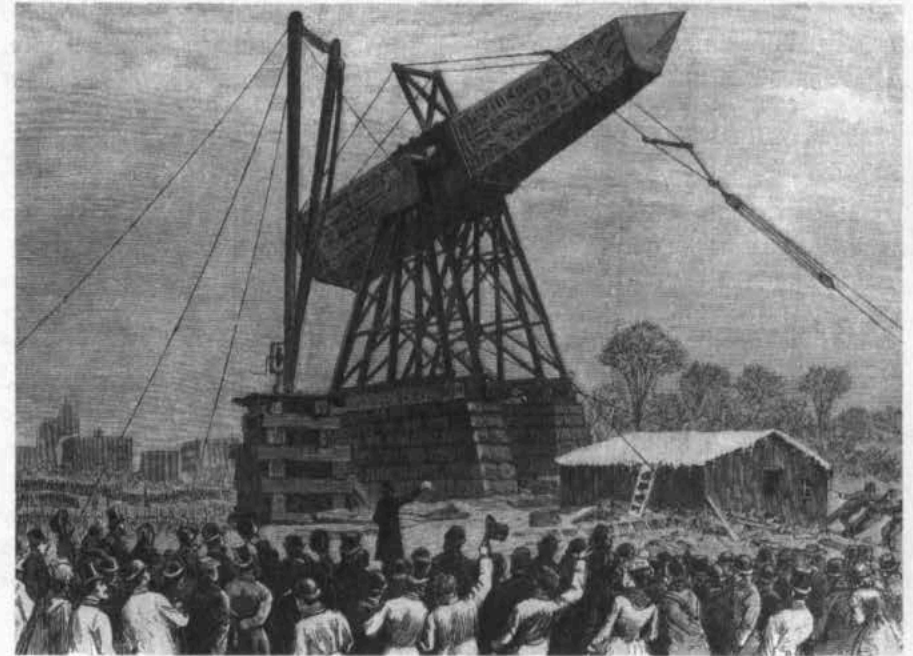
The pressure for statuary came primarily from below, from organized ethnic groups seeking concrete public recognition in bronze and stone of great men (and only men) from their countries of origin. Indeed, more than half of the

fifteen statues of individuals erected in the park in the nineteenth century were financed and promoted by ethnic associations: Johann Schiller, Alexander von Humboldt, and Ludwig van Beethoven by German Americans; Walter Scott and Robert Burns by Scottish Americans; Giuseppe Mazzini by Italian Americans; Thomas Moore by Irish Americans; and Albert Thorvaldsen (a sculptor) by Danish Americans. The choice of these mostly cultural figures is revealing: immigrant New Yorkers were emphasizing their status as "cultivated" people by honoring leading cultural (not political or military) figures in the city's most "cultivated" space. And as if to underline the message, the sponsoring associations invariably chose the sculptor from their own ethnic group: Gustav Blaeser for Humboldt; Giovanni Turini for Mazzini; Dennis Sheahan for Moore; Sir John Steel for Burns and Scott. Park rules might not permit formal ethnic gatherings, but the dedications of these statues sometimes turned into ad hoc ethnic festivals.⁵⁹

In at least one case, park statuary sparked conflict and competition between ethnic groups. With the four hundredth anniversary of Columbus's voyage approaching, Italian and Spanish Americans each asked for the prime location of the Fifth Avenue and 59th Street entrance to the park to celebrate *their* national hero. The park board rejected both proposals and offered the Italians Eighth Avenue and 59th, and the Spanish Americans an isolated site at the southern end of Mount Morris Park at Fifth Avenue and 120th Street instead. Editor Carlo Barsotti raised money from Italian Americans through his paper, *Il Progresso*, to pay for the thirteen-foot-high statue (sculpted by Italian Gaetano Russo) on its towering twenty-six-foot granite column. A crowd of ten thousand gathered on Columbus Day 1892 for the dedication, and Columbus Circle soon became what the *Times* called "a sort of Mecca," where "troops" of "swarthy sons of the Sunny South wander about the bit of marble, looking it over with the deepest interest."⁶⁰

Spanish Americans were disgruntled at being offered a "second class place." They turned it down and abandoned their project. Two years later the elite New-York Genealogical and Biographical Society unveiled its own statue of Columbus at the south end of the Central Park Mall. (The tribute to the "discoverer" of America—like the statue *The Pilgrim* erected in the park by the New England Society in 1885—could be seen as an "ethnic" assertion by native-stock Americans who felt beleaguered in a city more and more dominated by immigrants.) By the 1930s, however, the statue on the Mall had become the site for the *Día de la Raza* (Day of the Spanish Race) ceremonies organized by Spanish-speaking Harlemites, most of them from Puerto Rico.⁶¹

The city's immigrant groups were not the only ones to push for statues in the park, nor were the statues only of individuals. Sculptures honored Daniel Webster, Alexander Hamilton, and the fifty-eight members of the Seventh Regiment killed in the Civil War. And in 1871 the nation's telegraph operators presented a larger-than-life bronze of Samuel F. B. Morse. Four years earlier



Guidebooks directed park visitors to novelties like the Obelisk, brought from Egypt by William Vanderbilt and shown here being placed on a knoll west of the Metropolitan Museum of Art in 1881. "To gaze at the Obelisk was regarded as a far greater treat by the majority of park visitors than to watch the wondrous developments of nature," the *Herald* declared.

Morse and others had given the park Auguste Cain's sculpture *Tigress and Cubs*. Other private donors placed sculptures with "natural" themes—*Eagles and Prey* and *The Indian Hunter*—at sites in the park; these particularly appealed to parkgoers who thought that decorations should reinforce the distinction between the park and the city.

Commissioners let private donors take the initiative for almost all the statuary. Vaux and Mould's 1862 proposal for twenty-six statues of leading Americans at the Terrace—the park's most formal space—fell victim to cost overruns. When the Terrace was finished in 1873, it included only a fountain, with classical stone vases at the north end of the Mall. The life-size neoclassical bronze angel in the middle of the fountain was the only sculpture commissioned as part of the initial park design. Some critics thought the *Angel of the Waters* was too expensive (at sixty-three thousand dollars) or unsightly (it reminded them of a "servant girl executing a polka"). Even more criticism centered on the selection of the sculptor, Emma Stebbins, a sister of park board president Henry G. Stebbins, to produce the work. In retrospect, one might speculate that some of the criticism also stemmed from awarding such an important commission to a woman—the first time this had been done in New York.⁶²



Olmsted and Vaux hoped to restrict statues, such as this 1870 monument to Shakespeare by John Q. A. Ward, to the Mall and the entrance gates.

As sculpture gradually filled the park, immigrants came to pay homage to their cultural heroes, and guidebooks devoted considerable space to detailing each work and its location. The guidebooks (and newspapers) paid particular attention to the park's most spectacular piece, a seventy-one-foot-high obelisk snatched from Egypt over the objections of both Egyptians and Europeans and transported to America at William H. Vanderbilt's expense. It was erected behind the Metropolitan Museum of Art in 1881, where its ancient heritage (ca. 1461 B.C.) and "strange" hieroglyphic markings made it "one of the chief attractions of the grounds," in the words of one guidebook. Cultivated New Yorkers saw the appropriation of such a great monument of classical civilization as further testimony to their city's stature as "the metropolis of the Western World."⁶³

In 1873 the park board acted to restrict commemorative sculpture to the

Mall and the entrance gates and to require prior review of artistic merit by a committee made up of the presidents of the Metropolitan Museum of Art, the National Academy of Design, and the American Institute of Architects. Expert arbiters of taste and culture, the commissioners insisted, should control the ornamentation of the park. But the review committee was only advisory. It could not stem the pressure to commemorate immensely popular figures, nor did it approve sculptures of a quality everyone could endorse. The original park board had accepted only five of the twenty statues offered by donors. But ten more were added in the 1870s, and by the mid-1890s, there were twenty-four pieces. In 1897 the charter that incorporated the five boroughs into Greater New York established the Art Commission of the City of New York to govern the placement of works of art on city property; it was to be controlled by representatives of the art world—experts—not the public park board.⁶⁴

The City Park

The immigrant and working-class crowds who came to Central Park in growing numbers in the last two decades of the century asserted their right to enjoy the park in their own way. "The Sunday excursionist," a *Herald* reporter suggested in 1881, "is not in quest of quiet pleasures, as a rule: it is a sensation that he or she is looking for. To gaze at the obelisk was regarded as a far greater treat by the majority of the Park visitors than to watch the wondrous developments of nature as set forth in tree or shrub." In 1883, to the outrage of *Harper's Weekly*, one park commissioner even maintained that "the people don't care about country in the park." "The Mall, Terrace, and all the favorite promenades were as crowded as Broadway on a gala day," the *Herald* noted in a typical Sunday report, observing in another, "Every seat, every arbor, every nook was occupied, and the music of human voices and laughter drowned and silenced the precocious chirping and whistling of insects and birds. In these crowded centres the illusion of country was completely lost."⁶⁵

Olmsted bemoaned and fought the loss of the "illusion of country" that had formed the heart of the park's original aesthetic. In 1874 he persuaded the board to refuse permission "for any exhibition, show, or entertainment on the Central Park" that would charge a fee. But the commissioners' decision to use limited funds to keep up the popular concerts and skating rather than the natural landscape frustrated Olmsted. "I tell you," he wrote to a journalist in 1874, "that I think the park is going to the devil and have grave doubt whether the undertakings to provide a *rural* recreation ground upon such a site in the midst of a city like this was not a mistake, was not doomed to failure because of the general ignorance of the conditions of success and the impossibility of getting proper care taken of it."⁶⁶

Yet the natural features of the park did not disappear, despite the new



Central Park Mall, 1902: On Sundays the park became another crowded urban space.

crowds and new uses. Each spring, the grass turned green, trees leafed out, and the shrubs bloomed. And throughout the year, thousands, perhaps millions, came to observe nature, to wander through the Ramble, to enjoy the vistas. In the 1870s and 1880s, school principal James Herbert Morse regularly walked in the park, writing poems in his head, noting "signs . . . of the coming season of flowers," observing the "birds flitting and fluttering" in the shrubbery, and praising an open field surrounded by trees as a "fine broad amphitheatre for the reverberation of sound." At almost the same moment that Olmsted was writing *The Spoils of the Park*, Morse was enjoying the park according to the designers' intentions. "After three weeks of hard work and dissipation, parties, theaters, dinners, and clubs," Morse wrote in his diary in March 1881, "I am in the park, alone, with a joyous spring sunshine pounding down upon the world." A British visitor in the mid-1890s similarly found the park filled with "the open spaces, the varied outlines, the graceful curves which Nature everywhere supplies . . . and large expanses of grass, the greenest which I saw in the States."⁶⁷

But Morse saw more than natural beauty in his rambles through the park: panhandlers approached him for pennies, children ran across the lawns, his own children fed the animals at the menagerie, men sat on the lawns smoking pipes and reading scandal papers, and an elderly woman in a "shabby grey shawl" and with "ill-shod feet" picked dandelions to sell. And he partook of the new "urban" institutions that the park offered; on December 18, 1888, when the Metropolitan Museum of Art opened its first wing on park land, Morse



While many New Yorkers enthusiastically greeted new Central Park attractions like the zoo, statues, rides, and restaurants, others continued simply to enjoy contemplating nature.

participated in the ceremonies as a member of the Mendelssohn Glee Club, whose concert included an ode, "Of Glorious Birth Was Art," which Morse himself had written especially for the occasion.⁶⁸

Morse experienced Central Park not as an insulated "rural recreation ground" but as a city park that encompassed a wide range of people, sensations, and activities. As the social and physical landscapes changed, the park was becoming what Vaux had called a "many sided, fluent" public institution. And the contrasting groups of parkgoers, from dandelion pickers to lovers of art, and their contrasting ways of using the park mirrored the contradictions of the city itself.

The Eclectic Park

The eclecticism of the park resided not simply in the diversity of the crowds and their activities but also in the ability of people to interpret the same

experiences in *different* ways. One day (probably in the early 1890s), Annie Nathan Meyer rode through the park, looking at the Sheep Meadow and thinking about the "calming touch, the healing power that seems to reach out from these scenes." Then she turned to look at the other women in her carriage: "Have they seen the sheep, I wonder? One of the ladies opposite to me did bend forward, I remember, but merely to see a cape that was more elegant than hers flash by in a noiseless victoria."⁶⁹

Olmsted had worked to create a park for men like James Morse and women like Annie Nathan Meyer, not for the old woman gathering dandelions or the young woman surveying the latest fashions. But the effort to impose a unitary vision of the park proper, to insist that the "best use" lay in appreciating the natural scenery, remained illusory. As time went on, crowds of parkgoers and the experience of parkgoing became even more eclectic. It was not an experience of democratic social mixing, however. Rich and poor New Yorkers may have shared the "public" space of the park, but their differing circumstances structured how they used it.

The bon ton might drive on the East Drive of Central Park on a fall afternoon or stop at Mount St. Vincent after a sleigh ride. But they were less likely to join the sweaty crowd squeezed together on the Mall for the free Sunday afternoon concert. Even in 1871 a *Times* reporter noted how park visitors "quickly disperse in various directions. The boys to the ball-ground, the ladies to the lawns and seats around the music-stand, . . . the country visitors to the menagerie, and the nurses and babies to the Mall and goat carriages."⁷⁰

Two decades later, a *Sun* reporter viewed this choreography in sharper ethnic and class terms when he observed that the area around the Dairy and the Carousel was "a side to the Central Park distinct from the victorias, the cabs, and the carriage ways. . . . This part of the Park might be called the poor people's end of Central Park, or the foreign quarter." The reporter speculated that immigrant parkgoers "get their ideas from the pleasure grounds of German cities, where the classes separate and frequent their respective parts of the park or pleasure ground." Another article in the same issue acknowledged that Americans also "separated" out by class; it berated wealthy New York women for their ignorance of the park, since "their enjoyment of it is confined to the East Drive between four and six in the afternoon. Within five minutes of six the high-backed victorias . . . quickly disappear." Although the carriage parade had always been concentrated in a limited period of time, it was now also concentrated in a limited stretch of the park, as wealthy New Yorkers turned the East Drive (near Fifth Avenue) into the American equivalent of Hyde Park's "Rotten Row," the drive that attracted the richest Londoners with their carriages. About the preference for the East Drive Commissioner Henry Beekman commented, "I do not know why the East Drive should be so crowded, while the West Drive is comparatively free, except that the former happens at present to be the more fashionable."⁷¹

One way parkgoers responded to the growing heterogeneity was to draw



Well-to-do German-Jewish New Yorkers turned the Mineral Springs Pavilion at the northwestern end of the Sheep Meadow into a local replica of "Kissingen, Carlsbad, and other European waterplaces," the *Times* reported.

their own boundaries through patterns of use. Such self-segregation had a temporal as well as a spatial dimension: fashionable women on the East Drive on weekday afternoons, gentlemen's riding clubs on the bridle paths on weekday mornings, working-class families at the menagerie on Sunday afternoons, sporting men at McGown's Pass Tavern in the evenings. Some spots attracted quite specific groups. In the 1890s most of the early morning patrons of Vaux's Moorish-style Mineral Springs Pavilion were well-to-do genteel and Jewish German Americans—including leading ministers, bankers, lawyers, and brewers—who lived in upper Manhattan. A *Times* reporter found it reminiscent "of Kissingen, Carlsbad, and other European waterplaces."⁷²

There were demarcations by sex and age, as well. Children delighted in the zoo, Carousel, boats, swings, baseball fields, and pony and goat rides.⁷³ On weekdays in the spring and fall, nurses and governesses accompanied the children of wealthy New Yorkers to the park; on summer weekends, working-class parents brought their own children. On the pony and goat rides, rich and poor children met as customers and workers, not as playmates. Young men—schoolboys and "rude fellows"—held sway at the southwest Playground or the Sheep Meadow. Women favored the concerts and the croquet fields as well as

the Children's District; and they tended to avoid certain implicitly "male" park spaces. "Respectable" women stayed away from McGown's Pass Tavern, for example, when the sporting crowd gathered there.

Women and men also formed themselves into special interest groups in their use of the park. Tennis players, bicyclists, and model-boat racers were all park constituencies. Although some such interests—tennis, for example—often had particular class inflections, others transcended conventional lines of division. The social reformer Henry George and the socialite Julie Grinnell Van Rensselaer Cruger may have had little else in common, but both enjoyed biking in Central Park. Even nature lovers were now becoming a specialized group that could no longer be assumed to include all visitors. Thus, in the 1890s the parks department gave out permits for those who wanted to collect autumn leaves in Central Park. "Yesterday," the *Times* reported in October 1898, "the autumnal tints attracted a large number of the lovers of nature who are regarded by the Park officers and attendants as a class by themselves."⁷⁴

Even as the "classes" of users segregated themselves, using the park in their own ways, individuals could not help but rub shoulders. Immigrant working-class couples from the East Side tenement houses, the *Sun* reporter observed, routinely entered the park at the Fifth Avenue entrance and would "walk along the driveway and watch the people in carriages."⁷⁵ As they, in turn, were watched.

Some found what Henry James would later call the "polyglot" park and its "polyglot" visitors unsettling. A snobbish character in Israel Zangwill's early twentieth-century play *The Melting Pot* derided the park as having "no taste," only "modern sculpture and menageries!" *Munsey's Magazine* observed disapprovingly in 1895 that because of Central Park's popularity and accessibility, "some New Yorkers" had come to see it as "rather a commonplace picnic spot for the use of the masses, and, except in a carriage or astride a fine horse, to be avoided." But others appreciated, even celebrated, the pastiche, the mixing of disparate peoples and features. For them, Central Park resembled that quintessentially urban and eclectic theatrical form, the variety show or "vaudeville," as it came to be known in the 1880s. A "great charm of Central Park," wrote J. Crawford Hamilton in *Munsey's Magazine*, "is the marvelous variety of its scenery and embellishments," including the crowds. The Mall, said Hamilton, noting the plethora of "monuments of foreigners" and the "imported music discoursed by a band principally composed of imported musicians," was the "headquarters" of "cosmopolitanism."⁷⁶

William Dean Howells also liked the cosmopolitan Mall, but other prominent literary figures, editors E. L. Godkin and George Curtis (both longtime associates of Olmsted) among them, increasingly viewed the immigrant working class as a threat to civilization, particularly in the aftermath of Henry George's mayoral campaign. Almost at the same moment that Olmsted was fleeing the city's machine politics and settling in the Boston suburbs, Howells was making

the reverse migration, from Boston to Manhattan. And it was the urban and eclectic park—the Mall filled with "mostly foreigners"—more than Olmsted's pastoral park that intrigued him. "For me," he wrote of the immigrant crowd, "they all unite to form a spectacle I never cease to marvel at, with a perpetual hunger of conjecture as to what they really think of one another."⁷⁷

We can only conjecture as well. In the late nineteenth century, most New Yorkers of foreign birth or recent immigrant stock spent their social lives within insular ethnic communities, and the barriers and conflicts between those communities remained substantial. In 1870 religious and ethnic tensions culminated in the Elm Park Riot, which started in the commercial pleasure ground at 92nd Street and Ninth Avenue but spilled over into Central Park, apparently drawing park workers into the melee. What seems to have been the park's first murder occurred when a crowd of Protestant Irish "Orangemen" shot and stabbed William Kane as he walked through the park on his way home from work. (They mistakenly believed that he was one of a group of Irish Catholics who had attacked them earlier.) In the 1890s the Columbus statue became a magnet not only for Italian Americans but also for anti-Italian vandals, who threw mud at it.⁷⁸

Ethnic clashes were apparently an exception rather than a rule within Central Park. Perhaps most remarkably, African Americans, who (as the *New York Freeman*, a black newspaper, noted) "find it most unpleasant to visit a majority of resorts in New York and New Jersey," were apparently accepted as regular users of the park in the late nineteenth century. References to black parkgoers are scarce in the papers and other sources, in part because African Americans were only about 1.5 percent of the city's population in those years. White and black New Yorkers mixed in the park most often as employers and employed: coachmen and nurses were often black. But newspapers did occasionally remark on black visitors, usually describing them with the same reportorial conventions used for immigrants, though perhaps with some added condescension directed at their dress. One report noted a "colored lady" who "dazed the spectators with her paradisiacal outfit." Another commented on the "smart looking colored women with marvelously decorated male companions." Black-owned newspapers occasionally reported on the concerts, encouraged youngsters to get permits for baseball and picnics in the park, and noted prominent visitors "out driving" on the carriage roads.⁷⁹ This degree of racial integration in Central Park, however limited, is noteworthy, given the rise of Jim Crow laws in public spaces in the South in this period and ongoing de facto segregation in the North.

Some New Yorkers seem to have experienced the park as a place to transcend some of the boundaries that otherwise divided them. Standing in crowds at the zoo or amid the throng waiting for Sunday concerts, they may have seen themselves as part of a broader cosmopolitan public. The young German American who stopped to admire the statue of the Scottish poet Burns could

break free, in a small way, from the ethnic insularity that so strongly characterized urban life in this period. The 1884 concert crowd that cheered for *both* the Catholic "Ave Maria" and the Protestant "Nearer, My God to Thee" revealed a degree of mutual tolerance, if not appreciation, that would have been surprising a decade earlier.⁸⁰ Young Hungarians and Poles who chose to spend their Sunday at Central Park rather than Tompkins Square (located within their own Lower East Side neighborhood) may have been crossing part of the social divide. Having joined the heterogeneous throng at the park, they might more easily join the heterogeneous crowd parading for the eight-hour day or cheering Henry George.

Not everyone, of course, used the park in what Howells called "the spirit of fraternity and equality."⁸¹ Park use reinforced as well as dissolved social divisions. But out of the tensions and conflicts that accompanied the opening of the park to new users and new uses came a broader definition of the public. In claiming access to the park, in pressing for new policies in its governance, and in themselves contributing to the park's attractions, working-class New Yorkers in particular transformed the genteel (and, in practice, exclusive) Central Park of the 1860s into the eclectic (and common) Central Park of the 1890s.

Like the city, the park had become multivocal, incorporating different people, different experiences, and different meanings. The triumph of Vaux and Olmsted's design had been to turn a swampy and rocky "wasteland" into a beautifully composed pastoral landscape. The triumph of the New Yorkers who visited the park was to remake it in a way that realized the democratic implications of Vaux's vision of it as a "many sided, fluent, thoroughly American high art work."

13

A PUBLIC MENAGERIE AND TWO PRIVATE MUSEUMS

In March 1856 financier August Belmont wrote from the Hague to his father-in-law, Commodore Matthew Perry, about the new park proposed for Manhattan. Three years earlier, Perry had opened Japanese ports to American ships, and Belmont had been dispatched by President Franklin Pierce to the Netherlands to negotiate the opening of Dutch ports in the East Indies. Now the two men were thinking about opening uptown Manhattan to elite residential development. Just as they looked to the national government to facilitate private trade ventures, so too they saw new opportunities for private initiative in the city's provision of a public park. "Your project of buying and building on the Central Park seems a very good one," Belmont told the commodore. But if the park was to protect such investment and attract "nice neighbors," it would have to be properly managed. Thus, two years before he joined the park board himself, Belmont was already speculating on what rules would be necessary to "keep the fast trotting men and other rowdies" out of Central Park and its surrounding neighborhoods.¹

Belmont's speculations to his father-in-law went beyond the question of how public officials should manage the park in the best interests of adjacent landowners to a new kind of private initiative: the creation of a private zoological and botanical garden within the public Central Park. If the city set aside thirty or forty acres, Belmont suggested, a state-chartered private company headed by "a few of our spirited citizens," might take control of the property and open a zoo, "only to subscribers." "A great many much smaller places than New York, such as Brussels, Antwerp, etc. have similar establishments without any aid of Government," Belmont noted, "and they have succeed[ed] very well." How much greater the chances for success if the city provided the land.²

Belmont's vision of a private zoo and botanical garden was not realized.